Concepts in Middle Kingdom Funerary Culture

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Rune Nyord



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CHAPTER 4

How 'Royal' (and 'Mythical') Are the Coffin Texts? Reflections on the Definition and Function of Some Etic Concepts in a Middle Kingdom Funerary Text Corpus

Katja Goebs

The exact relationship of the funerary corpus of the Coffin Texts with its royal precursors, the Old Kingdom Pyramid Texts, continues to be a hotly contended topic among Egyptologists.[1] Issues debated include 1) The importance of format, such as the different types of text carrier—sunk stone relief on tomb wall vs. (predominantly) painted wooden coffin,[2] 2) Use and availability—where the observation that a much larger group of individuals, namely members of the high-ranking Middle Kingdom elite, had access to the Coffin Texts has entailed discussions about terms such as 'democratization' vs. 'demotization',[3]

1 Good summary in Mathieu, B. 'La distinction entre Textes des Pyramides et Textes des Sarcophages est-elle légitime?', in Bickel, S. and Mathieu, B. (eds.), *D'un monde à l'autre: Textes des pyramides & textes des sarcophages: Actes de la Table ronde internationale, textes des pyramides versus textes des sarcophages: Ifao, 24–26 septembre 2001* (BdÉ 139, Cairo, 2004), 247–262; for a more recent, brief, take on the matter see Willems, H., *Historical and Archaeological Aspects of Egyptian Funerary Culture: Religious Ideas and Ritual Practice in Middle Kingdom Elite Cemeteries* (Culture and History of the Ancient Near East 73, Leiden/Boston, 2014), 201 with n. 238. An extensive discussion is included in Antonio Morales' dissertation *The Transmission of the Pyramid Texts into the Middle Kingdom: Philological Aspects of a Continuous Tradition of Egyptian Mortuary Literature* (PhD Dissertation University of Pennsylvania (= UMI 3565179), Ann Arbor, 2013), in which the transition from Pyramid Texts to Coffin Texts and a number of the dynamics or strategies underlying potential transfers are discussed.

2 Although some Pyramid Texts survive on Middle Kingdom coffins also; synoptic edition by Allen, J.P., *The Egyptian Coffin Texts 8: Middle Kingdom Copies of Pyramid Texts* (Oriental Institute Publications 132, Chicago, 2006); see also Morales, *Transmission of the Pyramid Texts into the Middle Kingdom*, e.g. p. 30, where the author posits that about 400 Pyramid Text spells out of a total of 900 were transferred into, and edited for inclusion in, the Coffin Texts.

3 Discussed extensively in Willems, *Historical and Archaeological Aspects of Egyptian Funerary Culture*, 124–229, with evidence for both private individuals adopting Pyramid (and Coffin) Texts—commonly religious personnel involved in the cult of Old Kingdom kings' pyramid cults—as well as quantifications that demonstrate the extremely high status of the persons using the Coffin Texts, especially in Middle Egypt and Thebes. Even more recently, the very

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and 3) Content—such as the frequent use of captions and glosses in the Coffin Texts, the absence of certain central themes and a much higher incidence of dialogue in that later corpus,[4] paired with suggestions that regional religious ideas may be reflected in it. The latter have in turn led to a long-standing debate on the geographic origin of the two corpora in distinct (a northern vs. southern, or Middle Egyptian) cultural settings.[5] Many of these issues remain contentious in the scholarly literature and continue to be redefined in light of new findings.[6]

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concept of a 'trickle-down effect' in the use of these texts has been questioned on the basis of their including evidence for certain rituals—such as offering formulae—that are also, and earlier, attested in private funerary contexts (thus Smith, M., *Following Osiris: Perspectives on the Osirian Afterlife from four Millennia* (Oxford/New York, 2017), e.g. p. 51, esp. pp. 95ff.; id., 'Democratization of the Afterlife', in Wendrich, W. and J. Dieleman (eds), *UCLA Encyclopedia of Egyptology* (Los Angeles, 2009), http://escholarship.org.myaccess.library.utoronto.ca/uc/item/70g428wj). Such a, somewhat superficial, evaluation of the materials should be weighed against the evidence demonstrating beyond any doubt that the funerary text corpora as they are attested today include materials from various contexts and of varying geographical, historical, and functional provenance—a situation that is showcased, among other things, in the fact that no two pyramids or coffins display the exact same selection of texts. Just because an overlap can be observed in the use of some types of text in both the royal and private spheres does not dictate that this overlap extended to all conceptions included in a corpus such as the Pyramid Texts. While Smith acknowledges that both spheres may have drawn upon a common source for the texts that they share (*Following Osiris*, 154), this scenario to him provides 'further support for the view that rulers and subjects shared common aspirations for the hereafter during the Old Kingdom', thereby ignoring a number of conceptions that are in fact not attested in the private sphere. I will return to this point at the end of the discussion.

4 E.g. von Lieven, A., 'Nun sprach aber Osirtis zu Re … (Götter)Dialoge in den großen Corpora der ägyptischen Funerärliteratur', in El Hawary, A. (ed.), *Wenn Götter und Propheten reden: Erzählen für die Ewigkeit* (= Naratio Aliena? Studien des Bonner Zentrums für Transkulturelle Narratologie 3, Berlin, 2012), 97–98, who comments on differences between the two corpora, pointing out, for example, that a group of spells commonly known as 'Abscheusprüche', meaning 'Spells of loathing' or 'disgust', are absent from the Pyramid Texts as their royal users did not require them. On the increased use of dialogue in the Coffin Texts see Coulon, L., 'Rhétorique et stratégies du discours dans les formules funéraires: les innovations des Textes des Sarcophages', in Bickel and Mathieu (eds.), *D'un monde à l'autre: Textes des pyramides & textes des sarcophages*, 119–142. For the phenomenon and forms of dialogue in this corpus see also Bickel, S., 'Dialoge und das Dialogische in den altägyptischen Sargtexten', in El Hawary (ed.), *Wenn Götter und Propheten reden*, 65–82.

5 Summary e.g. in Gestermann, L., 'Sargtexte aus Dair al-Biršā: Zeugnisse eines historischen Wendepunktes?', in Bickel and Mathieu (eds), *D'un monde à l'autre: Textes des pyramides & textes des sarcophages*, esp. pp. 206–207.

6 To cite just one notable example from my own scholarly experience: A paper presented by Isabelle Pierre-Croisiau at a conference held at the IFAO in Cairo in 2001, later published as 'Nouvelles identifications de textes des sarcophages parmi les "nouveaux" textes des pyramides de Pépy Ier et de Mérenrê', in Bickel and Mathieu (eds.), *D'un monde à l'autre: Textes des pyramides & textes des sarcophages*, 263–278, identified, among various other *CT* numbers,

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Within this framework, the present paper concentrates on two of my own research foci. The first is the question of the 'Royalty' of the deceased as it is described in funerary texts, and in particular how it relates to the conspicuously non-royal dead buried in the Middle Kingdom coffins bearing the Coffin Texts and hoping to gain access to the afterlife by means of them. One might expect significant changes from the exclusively 'royal' precursor corpus both in terms of content—such as many fewer references to royal themes—and form—meaning potential semantic or grammatical shifts, which could prove that the royal prerogatives and terminology were not fully applied to the deceased buried in the coffins bearing the texts. Secondly, if much more briefly, I will comment on the occurrence and use of mythical materials in these texts. By examining definitions of these concepts, as well as evidence from the Coffin Texts that previous scholarship has adduced to justify their use in both describing and analyzing this corpus, I question to what an extent these terms are actually appropriate in this context. Providentially, pertinent evidence for both royalty and myth usually appears side by side in the sources under study.

1 Egyptian 'Kingship' and 'Royalty'—Etic vs Emic Concepts

In a volume concerned with questions of etic and emic concepts, I would like to begin by explaining why I view concepts of, and terms used to express, 'Kingship' and 'Royalty' as applied to the culture of ancient Egypt as etic—at least as a point of departure for my investigation. This is first and foremost due to the fact that many scholars to this day still seem uneasy about applying a straightforward translation of 'King' to the Egyptian terms most commonly seen as expressing equivalents to the modern institution. Uncertainty informs studies of both the linguistic (lemmatic, phonetic) derivations and the exact socio-political usage and range of associations.[7] The Egyptian title *njswt-bjtj* (or

a section of CT 1030 and thus a part of the *Book of Two Ways* in the pyramid of Merenre (ibid., p. 268; PT reference: M/A/N 13–14—corresponding to CT VII, 258a–259c). In this way, from one day to the next, the long-standing interpretation of the *Book of two Ways* as a local—and late—Hermopolitan creation had been debunked; it had been in question since the mid-1990s, when David Silverman published Lower Egyptian attestations (cf. 'Coffin Texts from Bersheh, Kom el Hisn, and Mendes', in Willems, H. (ed.), *The World of the Coffin Texts: Proceedings of the Symposium Held on the Occasion of the 100th Birthday of Adriaan de Buck, Leiden, December 17–19, 1992* Leiden 1996, 140–141).

7 See Leprohon, R., *The Great Name: Ancient Egyptian Royal Titulary* (Writings from the Ancient World 29, Atlanta, 2013), 17 for brief summary.

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nsw-bjt) is today most commonly translated as 'Dual King'[8]—in particular by those who wish to avoid the geographical connotations of the more traditional rendering 'King of Upper and Lower Egypt',[9] which is perceived as potentially misleading[10] and misrepresenting, among other things, the processes that led to the foundation of the Egyptian state as a straightforward 'conquest' of Lower Egypt at the hands of a southern principality.[11] Indeed, usage of the term (and its components, *njswt* and *bjtj*) in the funerary literature strongly suggests that this older translation does not cover all the potential meanings,[12] yet most Egyptologists seem to accept that *njswt*, *bjtj*, and *njswt-bjtj* are titles or epithets that refer to a person who is in many respects comparable to what a modern onlooker might perceive and designate as a 'king' or 'monarch'. The appropriateness of such an approach appears to be validated when one scrutinizes definitions of the most important terms commonly associated with the Egyptian ruler in a few highly regarded dictionaries and encyclopedias. The entry for 'Monarch' in the Merriam-Webster's *New College Dictionary*, for example, includes the following characteristics:

> A monarch is the sovereign head of state in a monarchy. A monarch may exercise the most and highest authority in the state [...] Typically a monarch either personally inherits the lawful right to exercise the state's sovereign rights (often referred to as the throne or the crown) [...] or is selected by an established process from a family or cohort eligible to provide the nation's monarch. Alternatively, an individual may become

8 As introduced by Baines, J., e.g. in 'Kingship, Definition of Culture, and Legitimation', in O'Connor, D. and D.P. Silverman (eds.), *Ancient Egyptian Kingship* (PdÄ 9, Leiden, 1995), pp. 3–47; esp. 9.

9 This is the way the title was translated into Greek on the Rosetta Stone; cf. e.g. Gardiner, A.H., *Egyptian Grammar, Being an Introduction to the Study of Hieroglyphs*, 3rd edn., Oxford, 1957, 73.

10 See Leprohon, *The Great Name*, 17 with references to a few other interpretations; for a relatively recent understanding involving different functions of the office holder see e.g. Kahl, J., '*nsw* und *bit*: die Anfänge', in Engel, E.-M., et al. (eds.), *Zeichen aus dem Sand: Streiflichter aus Ägyptens Geschichte zu Ehren von Günter Dreyer* (MENES 5, Wiesbaden, 2008), 307–351.

11 Classic account in Sethe, K., *Urgeschichte und älteste Religion der Ägypter* (Abhandlungen zur Kunde des Morgenlandes 18, 4, Leipzig, 1930); summary and contextualization also in Assmann, J., *Ägypten: Eine Sinngeschichte* (Munich/Vienna, 1996), 43–52.

12 See e.g. Goebs, K., *Crowns in Egyptian Funerary Literature: Royalty, Rebirth, Destruction* (Oxford, 2008), 376 (also p. 298 n. 658) for a brief discussion of how, at least in the divine and celestial spheres, areas other than terrestrial parts of Egypt inform the use of these terms.

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> monarch by conquest, acclamation or a combination of means. A monarch usually reigns for life or until abdication. […][13]

The *Encyclopedia Britannica*'s entry on 'Sacred Kingship', defined among other things as a more traditional and older form of monarchy, moreover describes it as:

> A religious and political concept by which a ruler is seen as an incarnation, manifestation, mediator, or agent of the sacred or holy […] the king, as the personified god, played the main role in the overall, and mostly ritualized cultural pattern. Politically, this entailed the exercise of power of one person over other persons or over a community (local, regional, or imperial) and in early times was general and not divided. Power could be exercised by only one person—one who simultaneously had the necessary physical (individual and corporate) and spiritual (psychic) strength and influence—over both people and objects.[14]

As regards the processes by which an individual assumed this position we read:

> The coronation or ascent to the throne by a king is an official act that most clearly shows the sacral character of the kingdom. […]: through ascent to the throne, the king is placed higher than other men, and the act of accession is connected with supernatural powers. […] In becoming someone else (a god), the king receives a new name, a throne name. […]
>
> The coronation […] was viewed as a cosmic new beginning, […]. The most important initial actions of sacred kingship—the ascent to the throne and coronation with proper insignia and king's robes—have remained the same in many modern cultures. The throne, crown, headdress, garment (as sign of dignity), and sceptre (the staff through which the rule is carried out) were originally believed to contain the power through which the king ruled. […]. In many cultures the […] throne, the crown, and the sceptre are viewed as divine and identified with gods and goddesses.[15]

13 'Monarch', in: *Webster's 11 New College Dictionary* (Boston, 2001), 707.

14 Westermann, C., 'Sacred Kingship', http://www.britannica.com/topic/sacred-kingship; accessed 16 January 2016.

15 Loc. cit. The article mentions some further rituals connected with sacred kingship, including anointment, cleansing, and ritual meals.

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Needless to say, anybody with even rudimentary background knowledge of the Egyptian state and its chief representative will recognize important aspects of Egyptian kingship in this summary, and—rather befittingly—the author of the latter entry proceeds to adduce several examples from ancient Egypt to underpin his arguments. This is significant within the theoretical framework of the present volume because also the single-most cited anthropological works on kingship and its associated rituals, the studies by Arthur Maurice Hocart, *Kingship*[16] and by Arnold van Gennep, *The rites of passage*,[17] draw heavily on Egyptian things. I first came to realize this when, in the course of my research on Egyptian crowns and the rituals associated with their bestowal, I recognized the (typically tripartite) structure of van Gennep's rites of passage in both Egyptian accession and transfiguration rituals,[18] followed by the realization that this coinciding had also been commented on by Hocart.[19] A little research on the biography of van Gennep revealed that he actually studied, among other things, Egyptology at the École Pratique des Hautes Études, however,[20] and is

16 Oxford 1927; second edition 1969. For his discussion of the relationship between earthly and celestial rule of both the gods and the king see, for example, pp. 7–20, 70–98.

17 Chicago 1960; translated from the original French (1909) edition by M.B. Vizedom and G.L. Caffee.

18 Goebs, *Crowns*, 376–377. The applicability of the tripartite structure of rites of passage has recently been questioned by Harold Hays, 'The End of Rites of Passage and a Start with Ritual Syntax in Ancient Egypt', in: Ambos, C. and L. Verderame (eds.), *Approaching Rituals in Ancient Cultures* (Pisa/Rome, 2013), 165–186, who argued that some Egyptian rituals have more than three parts, and that in some funerary ritual representations there is no clear narrative sequence—for example, when aggregate, complete, stages of a transfiguration can at times be represented at what appears to be the very beginning of such a ritual. There are several problems with Hays' approach, and this is not the place to discuss them in detail, but I would like to offer two comments: First, it should be kept in mind that the question of where a full 'part' of a ritual begins and where it ends, and which sub-sections should be counted towards such 'parts', may differ from culture to culture and/or lie in the (etic) eye of the beholder. Secondly, we cannot assume that a tomb representation of what appears to be a ritual sequence represents a true-to-life reproduction of that same ritual, from beginning to end. What is more, it would not have functioned as such a record for the people who were meant to see it—and we have to take their (potential) perspective in viewing these representations into account when trying to interpret. Regardless of whether such images and texts were aimed primarily at the deceased himself or at the visitors to the outer parts of his tomb, the aim of any such representation would have been, at least in part, to reassure these individuals that the deceased's transformation into an Akh had been successful as a result of due ritual process having been followed.

19 *Kingship* (2nd ed.), 83–84.

20 Belmont, N., *Arnold van Gennep: The Creator of French Ethnography*, translated from the French by D. Coltman (Chicago, 1979).

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the co-author of a little-known volume on Egyptian weaving techniques.[21] In other words, the at first sight quite abstractly deduced, etic, and hence purportedly objectively developed concept of ritual structures surrounding the institution of kingship, which are presented as near-universal by these comparative studies—and which I myself attempted to apply to the Egyptian evidence and then marveled at how neatly they applied also there—is in essence *based* upon that very same evidence, at least in part. I, for one, almost fell victim to a veritable circular argument, therefore—a cautionary tale for anybody working with etic models.

Whether true emic views can be isolated for ancient Egypt remains questionable, of course, not least since no living members of this culture remain. Anthropologists such as Marvin Harris questioned even the possibility of either truly emic or fully etic models,[22] considering it highly unlikely that, even in living societies, there could be any such thing as a 'cultural authority' that might be asked to present a 'true' image of their culture, and arguing that every observer's supposedly objective etic model might in fact turn out to be their own emic one. This has led some commentators to conclude that 'an interplay between what might be considered the emic models of the observer and the observed are as close as we can get to an etic level of analysis.'[23] Since we possess plenty of written evidence from Egypt that we know to translate quite well, however, and since—as illustrated above—we certainly have a whole range of our own emic models of kingship, which we can at least try to apply to the terms expressing the emic Egyptian counterparts to see how the two intermesh, the following pages will trace the usage of the Egyptian terms that are commonly translated as 'king' in the Coffin Texts and compare the statements they make with those models.

21 Van Gennep, A. and Jéquier, G., *Le tissage aux cartons et son utilisation décorative dans l'Egypte ancienne* (Neuchatel, 1916). An English translation has appeared only recently: *Cardweaving in Ancient Egypt*, translated from the French by B. Shapiro (San Francisco, 2010).

22 E.g. *The Rise of Anthropological Theory: A History of Theories of Culture. Updated version* (London, 2001), 568–604. Also id., 'History and Significance of the Emic-Etic Distinction', *Annual Review of Anthropology* 5 (1976), 329–350.

23 Barnard, A. and Spencer, J. (eds), *Encyclopedia of Social and Cultural Anthropology*, 2nd ed. (Abingdon/New York, 2010), 222.

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2 The Egyptian Terminology of 'Royalty'

My research produced 41 attestations for *n(j)swt*[24] (*Wb*[25] 2, 325.1–329.10; *TLA*[26] number 88040; 851639 if used as the epithet of a deity), a count that disregards the plentiful occurrences of *ḥtp-dj-njswt* offering formulae.[27] It stands against only 3 attestations for *bjtj* (*Wb* 1, 435.1–15, *TLA* 54240)[28] and 2 for *njswt-bjtj* (*TLA* 88060; both occurring in the same spell, *CT* 42).[29] In addition, there were 2 attestations for *nsyt*—'kingship' (*Wb* 2, 332.13–333.21; *TLA* 88090).[30]

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24 I have largely worked with the de Buck edition for this study, which provides an excellent synoptic layout. Most of my findings relate to a number of coffins or manuscripts and I think that conclusions can be drawn and formulated with relative certainty. On occasion I may be missing examples from coffin exemplars that are not included in this edition so that the numbers presented here are not to be understood as absolute. Pyramid Texts on Middle Kingdom coffins have not been included as the purpose of this paper is to assess the significance of the topos of 'Royalty' specifically within the funerary culture of the time and, potentially, in contrast to the conceptions encountered in the Pyramid Texts. But see Allen, *The Egyptian Coffin Texts 8* for such Pyramid Text copies. Indexes consulted to obtain the cited numbers are Borghouts, J.F. and D. van der Plas, *Coffin Texts Word Index* (Utrecht/Paris, 1998) and van der Molen, R., *A Hieroglyphic Dictionary of Egyptian Coffin Texts* (Leiden/Boston, 2000), augmented by my own searches of the texts. I have also benefitted from having my finds confirmed by Doris Topmann of the Berlin-Brandenburgische Akademie der Wissenschaften project *Structure and Transformation in the Vocabulary of the Egyptian Language*, who within this project is in charge of the Coffin Text evidence, as well as from an index of these texts compiled by Wolfgang Schenkel for his personal use—I am indebted to Professor Schenkel for permitting me to view his materials.

25 Erman, A. and W. Grapow (eds), *Wörterbuch der ägyptischen Sprache*, 7 vols. (Leipzig, 1926–1931).

26 *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae*, as produced by the above-cited Berlin-Brandenburgische Akademie project, and to be accessed via http://aaew.bbaw.de/tla/servlet/TlaLogin.

27 *CT* 45 (I, 197f), *CT* 48 (I, 214f), *CT* 49 (I, 222/B16C 98), *CT* 50 (I, 225a), *CT* 51 (I, 233a), *CT* 60 (I, 251f), *CT* 83 (II, 47a), *CT* 189 (III, 97i), *CT* 195 (III, 113q), *CT* 256 (III, 365a) *CT* 257 (III, 367a, 369a, 370c), *CT* 279 (IV, 26j), *CT* 313 (IV, 87m), *CT* 314 (IV, 94a), *CT* 317 (IV, 125b), *CT* 438 (V, 290f), *CT* 472 (VI, 1i), *CT* 484 (VI, 60c), *CT* 531 (VI, 125f), *CT* 557 (VI, 158k), *CT* 609 (VI, 223a), *CT* 629 (VI, 249i, n), *CT* 647 (VI, 268i), *CT* 660 (VI, 282d), *CT* 678 (VI, 305g), *CT* 695 (VI, 329a), *CT* 726 (VI, 357e), *CT* 741 (VI, 369p), *CT* 787 (VII, 1p), *CT* 803 (VII, 9p), *CT* 816 (VII, 15q), *CT* 826 (VII, 27n, (o)), *CT* 831 (VII, 310, p), *CT* 888 (VII, 100f), *CT* 926 (VII, 129g), *CT* 936 (VII, 137i), *CT* 947 (VII, 163l) (to which may be added *CT* 301 (IV, 52e), where L1Li miswrites the *šmʿtt* of other versions as *pr njswt*).

28 *CT* 317 (IV, 113a), *CT* 665 (VI, 291i), to which can be added an attestation of *sꜣty bjtj*, 'The twins of the *bjtj*', often an epithet of Shu and Tefnut (see below, 88 with n. 87), in *CT* 397 (V, 106a). An attestation in *CT* 695 (VI, 329g) is uncertain—see next note. Version B1Y of *CT* 60 moreover includes the title *ḥtmtj bjtj* with the name of the coffin owner in *CT* I, 253e, 254b.

29 *CT* 42 (I, 178p, 179a) (B2Bo, B3Bo). *CT* 695 (VI, 329g) includes the following group:  , which could potentially represent a (mis)writing of *njswt-bjtj*. See also below, 92 with n. 103.

30 *CT* 49 (I, 222/B16C), *CT* 313 (IV, 92n); *CT* 256 (III, 365e) is partially reconstructed and can thus not be considered a reliable attestation; see below, n. 68.

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I moreover searched for *ḥqꜣ* (*Wb* 3, 170.23–173.2; *TLA* 110360, 'ruler, leader, patron')—which yielded 23 attestations,[31] *jty* (*Wb* 1, 143.3–14, *TLA* 32930, 'sovereign, ruler, patron')—17 attestations,[32] and *jry-pꜥt* (*Wb* 2, 415.15–416.6; *TLA* 94060 'hereditary prince; nobleman')—17 attestations,[33] as well as *sr* (*Wb* 4, 188.3–189.9, *TLA* 138920, 'nobleman, magistrate, high official')—18 attestations.[34] A survey of context and usage revealed that *ḥqꜣ* and *jty* appear to be closely related to the more explicitly 'royal' terms, as they are frequently applied to the same entity that is also entitled *njswt* or *bjtj* within the same spell (see e.g. *CT* 45, 51, 313, 317, 647 discussed below). *Jry-pꜥt* and *sr*, by contrast, seem to be used differently and, within a given text, frequently appear as epithets of actors distinct from the former group. A good example is the common use, also well attested outside of the Coffin Texts, of *jry-pꜥt* for Geb,[35] who never holds the titles *njswt* or *bjtj* in this corpus. In fact, with the exception of a single spell (*CT* 345), where it is used as an epithet of Thoth, *jry-pꜥt* exclusively describes Geb in the Coffin Texts. *Sr*, by contrast is most often used in the plural and then refers to beings in a position of authority, yet secondary to a 'royal' figure such as the sun god or Osiris.[36]

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31 (Incl. pl. forms): *CT* 45 (I, 199b), *CT* 50 (I, 225c), *CT* 51 (I, 237e), *CT* 75 (I, 398d), *CT* 228 (III, 285b), *CT* 313 (IV, 87m), *CT* 317 (IV, 113a), *CT* 321 (IV, 146p), *CT* 325 (IV, 155b), *CT* 397 (V, 98b, d, f), *CT* 398 (V, 138b), *CT* 502 (VI, 87a), *CT* 554 (VI, 155f), *CT* 563 (VI, 162t), *CT* 641 (VI, 262l), *CT* 720 (VI, 347r, 348f), *CT* 763 (VI, 393h), (*CT* 822 VII, 22r?), *CT* 905 (VII, 111f), *CT* 1017 (VII, 236b); + fem. *ḥqꜣt*: *CT* 157 (II, 347a).

32 *CT* 60 (I, 248e B10C^{b} only), *CT* 268 (IV, 2b B1Bo only), *CT* 293 (IV, 45f), *CT* 316 (IV, 106b), *CT* 319 (IV, 143c), *CT* 320 (IV, 144e, 145a), *CT* 321 (IV, 146e, j), *CT* 335 (IV, 297d, 312a), *CT* 374 (V, 37c), *CT* 397 (V, 95g/118), *CT* 458 (V, 330j), (*CT* 578 VI, 194f—miswriting for *jt*, 'father'), *CT* 629 (VI, 250e), *CT* 647 (VI, 268h), *CT* 1006 (VII, 222k).

33 *CT* 8 (I, 25b), *CT* 16 (I, 47b), *CT* 42 (I, 179j), *CT* 45 (I, 197f), *CT* 131 (II, 151c, f), *CT* 226 (III, 253a, 258c), *CT* 345 (IV, 369a, 376g), *CT* 397 (V, 107k), *CT* 406 (V, 211e), (*CT* 540 VI, 135f), *CT* 556 (VI, 156j, m), *CT* 596 (VI, 214c), *CT* 917 (VII, 121i). In *CT* 573 (VI, 177g), S2C miswrites (*j*)*r*(*y*)-*pꜥ*(*t*) for *ꜥpr*.

34 (Incl. pl. forms and refs. to *ḥwt sr*): *CT* 4 (I, 14b B15C only; 15d), *CT* 7 (I, 22a), *CT* 132 (II, (151b—reading uncertain), 154d), *CT* 153 (II, 265e), *CT* 314 (IV, 94l), (*CT* 336 IV, 329d, l), *CT* 343 (IV, 350b), (*CT* 344 IV, 366b), *CT* 345 (IV, 376g B1P only), *CT* 469 (V, 394n B2L only), *CT* 540 (VI, 136l), *CT* 587 (VI, 208o, 209b, i), *CT* 642 (VI, 263e), *CT* 706 (VI, 337m), *CT* 836 (VII, 36j), *CT* 837 (VII, 37g), *CT* 1024 (VII, 245a).

Terms such as *nb*, 'lord, master, owner' (*Wb* 2, 227.5–230.14; *TLA* lemma number 81650) or *wr*, 'great one, magnate' (*Wb* 1, 328.14–329.18: *TLA* 47280) have not been included in this study as they have a broader spectrum of uses and connotations and are near ubiquitous.

35 See Gardiner, A.H., 'The Memphite tomb of the General Haremhab', *JEA* 39 (1953), 10; Leitz, Chr., et al. (eds), *Lexikon der ägyptischen Götter und Götterbezeichnungen*, VIII (Orientalia Lovaniensia Analecta 116, Leuven/Paris, 2002), 688 O.1. Example e.g. *CT* 45 (I, 197f) discussed below.

36 A striking case is *CT* 345 (VI, 376g), where B1P replaces the singular occurrence of the epi-

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Njswt is thus, without a doubt, by far the most important category of 'king' in the Coffin Texts. A first, impressionistic, analysis of this evidence might suggest that if a primary concern of these compositions had been to express the cited 'Dual Kingship' over two lands or domains on the model of the Egyptian rulers for whom the royal precursor corpus, the Pyramid Texts, were composed (or compiled), we would expect many more references to either *bjtj* (in the same or in related spells), or to the combined form *njswt-bjtj*. But this is not the case. Instead, one observes a clear pattern in the use of *njswt*: In the majority of attestations the title is associated with Osiris, in a smaller but still significant group with Horus (who also once appears as *bjtj* in this corpus—see CT 665 below). And, as we shall see, in the lion share of cases the title is used within descriptions of cosmic scenarios that have as their theme the seamless transition of the various phases of the solar cycle, which is cast in terms of a succession of celestial rulers.[37] In what follows, I present the different areas of use of the titles *njswt* and *bjtj* in the—mostly mythical—scenarios described in the Coffin Texts, with a view to establishing whether an overlap or equivalence with modern concepts of royalty, as offered in the cited Encyclopedias, can be proven.

thet *jry-pʿt* for Thoth in the other versions with that of *sr nṯrw m jwnw*, 'Prince/Magistrate of the gods in Heliopolis'.

37 For this mythical concept see also Goebs, K., *'Njswt nḥḥ*—Kingship, cosmos, and time', in Hawass, Z. and Pinch-Brock, L. (eds.), *Egyptology at the Dawn of the 21st Century. Proceedings of the Eighth International Congress of Egyptologists, Cairo, 2000* vol. 2 (Cairo, 2003), 238–253. For the relationship between myth(s) and funerary texts, especially their performance in the context of funerary rituals, see the musings of Jan Assmann and Martin Bommas, *Ägyptische Totenliturgien 1: Totenliturgien in den Sargtexten des Mittleren Reiches* (Heidelberg, 2002), 20–37, who speak of the phenomenon of the 'Statuscharakteristik', which features prominently in these texts. The authors employ this term to better define the ritual goal of transfiguring the deceased recipient of the cult by asserting his or her identity with a powerful, *ꜣḫ*-effective, inhabitant of the afterlife world. Such 'Zielgestalten' are—by definition—divine and thus are normally well-known mythical actors; as such they 'function' (my term) in mythical scenarios and constellations.

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3 'Royal' Concepts in the Coffin Texts

3.1 *Ideas and Processes of Succession—the Transition from Night to Day / Day to Night*

3.1.1 *CT* 60 (I, 251f) (B10C[a, b, c, d], B4C, B1Y)[38]

CT 60 presents an excellent example of a cosmic succession. We witness the appearance of 'The God in his Shrine' (*nṯr m kꜣr=f*)—a common reference to Osiris in other contexts, and the deceased is explicitly called Osiris at the end of the text. This identity is further borne out by the mythical actors and locations enumerated: Geb is his father and protection, Nut has born him, his living soul is in Djedet/Mendes; Seth and company are warded off and afraid. The deceased (as Osiris) then appears to be joined by the 'One with Fair Face' (*nfr ḥr*), Ptah-Sokar, at the prow of his barque. Bastet, daughter and first-born of Atum, is his protection:

CT I, 250b:

r ḥḏt tꜣ	… until day dawns,
r ḥꜣt=k r ḫrt nṯr	until you descend to the realm of the dead.

There follows a brief description of cosmic Maat in terms of all the mythical actors we might expect in such a context. This passage is clearly marked as separate from the rest of the text by being presented as reported speech, addressed to the deceased in his mythical role, and for his benefit. It is here that we understand the particular role of the various mythical actors within this cosmic scenario:

CT I, 250g–251f:

ḏdt n jmj-kꜣr=f	What is said to Him in his Shrine:
Rʿw ḏs=f m nb r ḏr	*'(When) Re himself is the Lord of All,*
dj=f jwt nṯrw m šmsw=f	*he causes the gods to come in his following*
nʿj wjꜣ jtḥ(w) mty	*as the barque travels, it being dragged straight on.*
ḥꜣj nṯr r ḫrt-nṯr	*(But) when the god descends to the realm of the dead*
jb=f nḏm	*contentedly—*

38 For the abbreviations denoting the different coffins and other text carriers see e.g. de Buck, *Coffin Texts* I, xvii–xviii; Lesko, L., *Index of the Spells on Egyptian Middle Kingdom Coffins and Related Documents* (Berkeley, 1979), 7–11. Note that, in the translations offered, I do not normally comment on the various grammatical issues and potential alternative renderings.

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Ḥrw m njswt *Horus is njswt-king,*[39]
jr.n=f n=f sꜣ (j-)mr=f *having acted for him as "Beloved Son"'.*

The 2nd person address to the deceased then resumes. While it is not explicit whether the 'descending god' is Re or Osiris, the framing statements render it most likely that the deceased as Osiris—the 'God in his Shrine'—is being presented with the reassuring account of how the solar cycle infallibly works and as such includes Horus, whose roles straddle the solar and Osirian mythical complexes.[40] For it is explicitly Horus who steps in as cosmic deputy and successor of his predecessor, and earlier and ensuing passages suggest that this take-over is timed at dawn: Bastet as solar daughter protects the deceased until day dawns and he goes down to the realm of the dead. Later in the text the god's *wryt*-hall is 'what Re made for him for his protection,[41] so that he might be in it until dawn' (*wryt=k m ḥwwt nṯr m jrt Rʿw m sꜣ=k wn=k jm=s r ḥḏt-tꜣ*). The Horizon and its various component parts (beams, curtain, etc.) then seem to be shut closed. When the day dawns (*wbn hrw*) in the east of the sky, it is there that it shines (*psḏ*) on the breast of the deceased—in a striking verbal description of the widespread icon showing Osiris being revived by means of solar rays. As Osiris, both night and day belong to the deceased (*jw n=k grḥ ntk hrw Wsjr*). The spell ends by invoking Horus, who is now the 'Lord of life' (*Ḥrw nb ʿnḫ*) and travels to numerous locations.

For the purposes of our discussion the use of the concept of *njswt*-king(ship) to indicate life in, and seemingly dominance over, the sky is notable; the epithet *nb r ḏr* is used in parallel to *njswt*. When Re rules, the gods follow him and the barque travels properly, but when the god sets in the horizon (and enters

39 Faulkner, R.O., *The Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts* I (Warminster, 1973), p. 55 translated 'He is happy for Horus is king'. Horus may appear as *njswt nṯrw* already in the Pyramid Texts, thus in PT 570 §1458e (P).

40 If we consider that Horus is in many contexts a pre- or early sunrise celestial deity, as unequivocally expressed in the Horian forms Harakhte and *ḥrw-dꜣtj*, to name but a couple, then both Re and Osiris could be affected by this changeover of rule at the respectively opposite end of the cosmic cycle: Re descends into the *d(w)ꜣt* at nightfall and Osiris (in his manifestation Orion—which is explicit in many spells from both the Pyramid and Coffin Texts)—at day-break. See e.g. Krauss, R., *Astronomische Konzepte und Jenseitsvorstellungen in den Pyramidentexten* (ÄA 59, Wiesbaden, 1997), 146–204, who moreover presents evidence suggesting that Horus represents one mythical form of the morning star, see ibid., pp. 216–234; 265–275; summary also in Goebs, *Crowns*, 19–20.

41 *Wb* 1, 332.13, as a funerary ritual structure associated with the preparation of the body; see also Guilhou, N., 'Rituel funeraire au Moyen Empire: L'ouryt et la lutte contre les insects necrophages', *Bulletin Cercle Lyonnais d'Égyptologie Victor Loret* 8 (1994), 25–34.

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the realm of the dead), then 'Horus is *njswt*-king'—a situation that is later also paraphrased by 'Horus is the Lord of life'.[42]

3.1.2 *CT* 49 (I, 222; B16C 98)

A similar succession of celestial rulers involving the title of *njswt* is envisaged in coffin B16C's version of a part of *CT* spell 49. The text describes Isis and Nephthys' mourning of Osiris,[43] who appears as 'Lord of the White Crown' (*nb ḥḏt*)[44] and must await the arrival of Horus from Heliopolis. In the meantime, Anubis acts as vizier[45]—adding nuance to the politically inspired scenario evoked here for the benefit of the deceased. Succession from father to son is once again the decisive episode, with the latter being granted his father's seat in the celestial barque. This privilege coincides with a royal status:

B16C 98

mk sꜣ=k r ḥꜣt (*wjꜥ*)	Behold, your son is at the prow of the barque,
dy n=f nst m kꜣr	he has been given the seat in the cabin/shrine
jw=f grt m njswt	and *he* is thus *njswt*-king.

CT 787 (VII, 1p; M2NY)—when emended on the basis of the parallel *BD* chapter 119—may be referring to a similar scenario when it has the speaker first identify as the eldest son of his father, 'the son of Nut', and later proclaim that he has 'arisen as the king of gods' (*ḫꜥ.kj m njswt nṯrw*).

42 Note that this spell has been included in the group of spells identified as funerary liturgies, and specifically as forming part of the 'Liturgie *ḫnmw*', by Assmann and Bommas, *Altägyptische Totenliturgien* 1, 309–332. As I have stated for other contexts (e.g. Goebs, *Crowns*, 295, 349–350 with reference to the Cannibal Spell), expressing a certain myth, or a group of specific mythemes, does not preclude a text from being used as an accompaniment of rituals, and Assmann's and Bommas's understanding does not limit or contradict the analysis presented here for the use of royal topoi in the Coffin Texts. Also they interpret the present text, which in their scheme accompanies the final stage of the hourly vigils of the night (*Stundenwachen*), as referring to sunrise. See also above, n. 37, for the authors' understanding of the use of myth in such texts.

43 Assmann and Bommas interpret also this spell, as well as *CT* 45 and 51 cited below, as part of a performance during an hourly vigil episode in the course of funerary rituals (*Altägyptische Totenlitugien* 1, 266–276). See the previous note.

44 Goebs, *Crowns*, 115–118.

45 B10C^{b}: *ṯꜣtj* B10C^{c}, B13C: *tꜣjtj ṯꜣtj*; B12C *tꜣjtj sꜣb ṯꜣty*, B16C: *tꜣ*(*tj*) *sꜣb*.

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3.1.3 *CT* 45 (I 197f) (B10C[b, c], B12C, B13C, B16C, B17C, B1Y)

As indicated, evocation of the kingship of Osiris is the most prominent use of royal topoi in the Coffin Texts. A good example is *CT* 609 (VI, 222i–223a), which asserts of the deceased: 'He is Osiris—he is your *njswt*-king!' (*Wsjr pw njswt=ṯn pw*).[46] In some cases the god's name is not even made explicit—Osiris's association with the title *njswt* was apparently so characteristic and innate that further specification was not required, as we shall see. In several spells his legitimate succession of Geb is moreover emphasized. Thus in *CT* 45,[47] where the deceased takes on a variety of divine identities aimed at ensuring his continued existence in the sky. He appears, among other things, as the sun god—Re and Atum, Hathor has anointed him, having given him life daily in the West like Re. He is more *ꜣḫ* and *bꜣ* than the southern and northern gods, and the gods of the horizon and crews of the solar barque are invoked. The mythical associations then move over to the Osirian side of the solar cycle.[48] Geb, as the deceased's father, has helped him and has incapacitated (*dr*) his foes, while Anubis makes his savor sweet. The deceased appears at the prow of the barque (*jw=k ḫˁ.tj m ḥꜣt wjꜣ*), followed by:

CT I, 197f

ntk njswt sꜣ jrj-pˁt You are the *njswt*-king, son of the *jry-pˁt*-Prince

—and thus of Geb.[49] In conjunction with ensuing references to his being embalmed by Anubis as well as to several Osirian cultic locations, the identity of the *njswt* in question as Osiris is thus assured; he is moreover invoked as the Lord of all that exists and ruler of all that does not (*nb n ntjw ḥqꜣ n jwtjw*). Eventually, the speaker reveals himself to be his son Horus (*jnk sꜣ=k Ḥrw*) and later also his *sꜣ-mr*/beloved-son priest, who accomplishes his vindication in the tribunal and endows him with his head at the command of Re. In this way, the

46 S5C, S10C, S11C, S12C, S6P.

47 This spell, like a few others cited here (e.g. *CT* 42) have been attributed to a ritual sequence that according to some authors may in origin have belonged into a royal coronation ritual by some scholars (see e.g. Faulkner, *Coffin Texts* I, 35 with n. 1); it also forms part of a spell sequence that Assmann and Bommas have named 'Liturgie *CT*.2' and identified, like a few other texts cited here, as part of the rituals surrounding the hourly vigils (Assmann and Bommas, *Altägyptische Totenlitugien* 1, 60–68; 233–247). See 75 with nn. 42–43 above and also the discussion of *CT* 51 on p. 78 below for this issue.

48 See Goebs, *Crowns*, e.g. pp. 42–44, on the complementary roles of Osiris and Re from the Pyramid Texts onwards.

49 See above, 71 with n. 35.

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deceased can be 'seen every day' (*mȝȝ.t(w) rˁ nb*)—a typical reference to one of the expected outcomes of a transfiguration with ensuing solar or stellar existence in the celestial afterlife.[50]

Also *CT* 45 hence uses the mythical topos of Osiris's kingship to indicate the deceased's continued control over his desired life-situation, namely entitlement to funerary and other provisions and the resulting continued celestial life as this prototypical ruler of the afterlife. However, the Osirian one is only one of the divine associations mobilized to accomplish this—the others are solar in character and underline the deceased's wish to be present in the sky, and hence 'live', through the diurnal and nocturnal parts of the solar cycle alike. This is equally pronounced in the mythically rather similar *CT* 50.

3.1.4 *CT* 50 (I, 225a) (B10C$^{b,\ c}$; B12C, B13C, B16C, B17C)

Like *CT* 45, this long text first describes sunrise but then moves over to Osirian themes. 'Re rises (*ḥrˁj*) from the double gates', Harendotes is glad, and Anubis is in his castle (*m ḥnw ˁḥ=f m wnwt=f nt sḥ-nṯr*). The latter attends to the 'Lord of Gods', who eventually appears on the throne of Geb and is acclaimed in Busiris. In other words, Osiris is meant also here. The deceased is identified with him and appears at the prow of the barque; most versions then specifically identify him as the *njswt*-king of the Lower sky (*pt ḫrt*)—seemingly referring to the old association of Osiris and the constellation Orion:

CT I, 225a:

mk ṯw grt r/m	Behold, you are thus
njswt n pt ḫrt	the *njswt*-king of the Lower sky.[51]

As such he rules (*ḥqȝ*) the ones on their thrones—the nighttime inhabitants of the stellar sky[52]—and this nocturnal scenario is underpinned by mention of the night-barque later on. Seth and the makers of tumult are warded off. Ultimately, the moon god Thoth reveals himself to be the reciter and helper of Osiris, who is responsible for his transfiguration and the warding off of his enemies (*jnk sȝ sȝ=k mtwt mtwt=k sbȝ.n ṯw* (*m*) *ḥnw jtn n-mrwt sȝḫ ṯw sḫr*(*w*) *n=k ḫftjw=k*).

50 E.g. Goebs, *Crowns*, 17 (in connection with the *bȝ*), 102–104; for discussion of the theme of restoring the head in the Coffin Texts see Nyord, R., *Breathing Flesh: Conceptions of the Body in the Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts* (CNIP 37, Copenhagen, 2009), 145–149.

51 B12C, B13C, B16C, B17C; B10C$^{b,\ c}$ simply write *njswt pt*.

52 See also the discussion of *CT* 678 and *CT* 195 below.

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3.1.5 *CT* 51 (I, 233a) (B 10C[b, c]; B12C[a, b], B13C, B16C, B17C)
Also *CT* 51, which follows on *CT* 50 on several coffins, demonstrates the essential association of Osiris with the title of *njswt*. The text begins with an appeal to mourn him:

jm ḥr njswt Wail about the *njswt*-king,
nj wnt ky sꜣ Gb for there is no other son of Geb.[53]

Even though the god's name is not specified, the surrounding mythemes leave no doubt that Osiris is meant. Injury was inflicted on him by his brother and he is in his hand, but his resurrection follows, of course, and as 'Lord of the West' his barque is seen by Re upon his rising in the East of the sky, which yet again implies a changeover from day to night. This is underlined further by declaring him a son of Harakhte and ennobled as the 'Ruler of the horizon' (*sʿḥ(w) m ḥqꜣ ꜣḫt*).

As our discussion is concerned specifically with the question of 'how royal' the Coffin Texts are, some interpretations of *CT* 51, as advanced by scholars such as Raymond Faulkner as well as Jan Assmann and Martin Bommas, should be mentioned. Faulkner took the opening phrase of this spell to indicate that it had in origin been a royal funerary text.[54] In this he is followed by Assmann and Bommas, in whose treatment of funerary liturgies in the Coffin Texts *CT* 51 is a part of their liturgy *CT*.2. Basing themselves on the work of Peter Jürgens,[55] they assert that this liturgy, just like their liturgy *CT*.1, held a status largely independent from the Pyramid Texts and was likely composed somewhat later. However, they tentatively except *CT* 51 from this interpretation—exactly because of the opening line *jm ḥr njswt*, which seems to reveal an older Pyramid Text, and hence royal, context also to them.[56]

It is my hope that the evidence presented here may serve to demonstrate that themes and associations of royalty appear throughout the Coffin Text corpus and cannot be used as reliable proof of 'older' Pyramid Text materials and conceptions. A particularly instructive example of this is *CT* 313, as it contains various markers of being a later, and specifically Coffin Text, composition (for

53 *jm* 'wehklagen', *Wb* 1, p. 77.12–13; *TLA* 24660; discussion also in Assmann and Bommas, *Totenliturgien* I, 292.

54 *Coffin Texts* I, 50 n. 1.

55 Jürgens, P., *Grundlinien einer Überlieferung der Sargtexte: Stemmata und Archetypen der Spruchgruppen 30–32 + 33–37, 75(–83), 162 + 164, 225 + 226 und 343 + 345* (GOF IV: Ägypten 31, Harrassowitz, 1995).

56 Assmann and Bommas, *Totenliturgien* I, 66 with n. 105; their translation of the text on pp. 290–292.

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which see below), yet is particularly rich in 'royal' associations. In offering the single most elaborate presentation of Osiris's kingship and of his being succeeded by Horus found in the Coffin Texts, the text situates important episodes of this myth in Herakleopolis Magna—in a manifestly post-Old Kingdom development.[57] For the purposes of our discussion, *CT* 313 moreover adds to the image of royalty sketched so far an illustration of the fact that preeminence in the sky may be expressed, besides by attributing a royal title, also by reference to royal symbols, such as thrones, crowns, scepters, and further items of insignia, and it is hence discussed in a separate section here.

3.2 *Coronation and Attribution of Insignia—the Royal Appearance of the Deceased*

3.2.1 *CT* 313 (IV, 87m) (B5C)[58]

This text is entitled a spell for 'Transforming oneself into a falcon' (*jrt ḫprw m bjk*) and thus a celestial inhabitant of the sky on the model of the sun god. In describing what appears to be a Herakleopolitan kingship, the text employs the Atef-crown as an item of both Osirian and Horian insignia. Here it is of note that the Atef is not attested in the Pyramid Texts, or any other earlier religious composition.[59] What is more, *CT* 313 includes extensive examples of dialogue, a characteristic marker of Coffin Text compositions.[60] Here Osiris speaks to

57 See now Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, L., *Naref and Osiris Naref: A Study in Herakleopolitan Religious Traditions* (ZÄS Beihefte 3, Berlin/Boston, 2017), 117–119. To what extent royal conceptions of Dynasties 9 and 10 may have contributed to the development of the royal associations of Osiris in the Coffin Texts is an interesting question but has to remain largely speculative; it is investigated by Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, op. cit., 118 and in her paper 'The role of Osiris in the Mythological Cycle Devised around Herakleopolis Magna and its Territory', in: Kousoulis, P. and N. Lazaridis, (eds), *Proceedings of the Tenth Egyptological Congress of Egyptologists, University of the Aegean, Rhodes 22–29 May 2008* (OLA 241, Leuven, 2015), 1173–1185.

58 For discussion of this text see e.g. Faulkner, R., 'Coffin Texts Spell 313', *JEA* 58 (1972), 91–94; Buchberger, H., *Transformation und Transformat, Sargtextstudien I* (ÄA 52, Wiesbaden, 1993), 470–497, Goebs, '*njswt nḥḥ*', Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, 'The Role of Osiris'.

59 See Goebs, *Crowns*; also ead., 'Crown (Egyptian)', in: Uehlinger, C., et al. (eds), *Iconography of Deities and Demons in the Biblical World* (Leiden, Brill, in press); digital pre-publication at: https://www.academia.edu/11958136/Crown_Egypt_for_IDD, p. 10/30.

60 Coulon, 'Rhétorique et stratégies du discours dans les formules funéraires', esp. pp. 134–136, who links this characteristic to the development of an 'art of debating' in the First Intermediate Period. See also von Lieven, A., 'Nun sprach aber Osiris zu Re', 83–104, who notes the declining importance of dialogue in later corpora of funerary texts, which she interprets as being due to those texts having been composed specifically for funerary use while the earlier corpora, from Pyramid Texts to Book of the Dead, were largely derived from originally ritual contexts. As regards the few examples of dialogue in the Pyramid Texts

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Horus about his transformation into, and new identity as, ruler, after Re and Atum, in front of the Enneads, have crowned him with the Atef-Crown.[61] Osiris has his uraei on his brow, his Atef on his head, his staff in his grasp and his knife in his grip; Maat is on his shoulder and Isfet under his feet. He exercises many regal prerogatives, which include promoting or advancing positions (*sḫnt swt*) and obstructing his enemies (*wdj sḏbw nw ḫftjw*); these are justified by reference to his royal status (*CT* IV, 87m):

ḏr-ntt ///	because ///
ḫ^ꜥ.kw m ḥqꜣ [*//// n pt*][62]	I have appeared as the ruler [//// of the sky]
njswt n tꜣ	and the *njswt*-king of the earth.

Thoth then arrives to assist him at the command of Atum. Later in the text Horus demands the same prerogatives that Osiris had received from Thoth. Among other things, Horus is said to have gone forth (*prj*) 'in the (various) manifestations of the kingship' (*m ḫprw nsyt*),[63] which are then specified further: Like his father, Horus displays all the external markers of the office, including uraeus, Atef-crown, etc. (*jꜥrt=j m ḫnt=j ꜣtf(w)=j ꜥꜣw m tp(=j) …*) and appears as a divine falcon, just 'like the manifestations of Re' (*mj ḫprw nw Rꜥw*).

There follows a description of the various aspects of Horus's kingship and these comprise those of all the office holders, of all the divine generations that make up the myth of the complete cosmic cycle:

CT IV, 93c–q:

ḥqꜣ.n=j jdbwy	I have ruled the two shores
jwꜥ.n=j nswt Ḥrw	I have inherited the thrones of Horus
jtj.n=j ꜣḫt Ḫprj	I have seized the horizon of Khepri and

the author notes that the deceased king in these compositions is treated as much more of an equal of the gods addressing him than he is in the Coffin Texts, where interrogations and the testing of his knowledge is common and the deceased has to prove his worth before he is admitted to the afterlife.

61 Cf. Goebs, *Crowns*, 62–69.

62 See De Buck, *Coffin Texts* IV, 87 n. 8*.

63 Note that *CT* IV, 91f seems to add a further term of royalty, writing what appears to read *nsw=j m ꜣḫ-bjt*, translating as 'I am kingly / regal (?) in Khemmis'. In light of the preceding sentence, which speaks of the deceased's birth by Isis, it is more likely that we are looking at a miswriting for *ms(w)=j* 'I was born in Khemmis', however. Paul Barguet, emending slightly differently, translated 'elle m'a mis au monde dans Akh-bit' (*Les Textes des sarcophages égyptiens du Moyen Empire* (Paris, 1986), 445).

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ḥms.n=j ḥr st jt=j Wnn-nfr	I have sat on the throne of my father Wenenefer
m ḏd Rʿw	according to the utterance of Re,
m wḏ Gbb	the command of Geb,
m smn Ḏḥwty	and the confirmation by Thoth.
…	
pr.kw m Ḥrw mɜʿ-ḫrw	I have come forth as the justified Horus,
m ḫprw nw Ḥrw	in the manifestations of Horus—
jw rn=j mj rn=f	my name is like his name,
ḫprw=j mj ḫprw=f	and my forms are like his forms.

But not only that—the deceased *combines* in himself the identity of the most important cosmic actors, identifying not only with Horus but simultaneously with Osiris:

jnk Wsjr sɜ Gbb stj Rʿw	I am Osiris, son of Geb, and deputy of Re.
…	…
nj sk(w)=j nj sk(w) rn=j	I will not perish, and my name will not perish—
jnk m tɜ pn ḏt	I will be in this land forever.

Like no other text this spell showcases the philosophy underlying the use of kingship terminology and mythology in the Coffin Texts. The deceased wishes to attain eternal life in the celestial hereafter and envisages his existence there as modelled on that of the most conspicuous, and thus dominant, beings—the frequent references to his being 'seen' as well as his assertion that he will not 'perish' (*skj*) underline these aspirations. These celestial actors are conceptualized in terms of a system of political rule and succession on the model of the terrestrial patrilineal succession of a king and his first-born son. Accordingly, and in order to ensure his eternity, the deceased refers to himself as both Osiris, son and successor of Geb—who is at the same time the deputy (*stj*) of the Sungod when the latter has set—but also as Horus, son of Osiris and Isis. He likens himself to these deities both in terms of their legitimate rule and prerogatives but also in their appearance, adopting the same paraphernalia that mark their pre-eminence and role as rulers over different parts of the cosmic cycle. These royal symbols include thrones, crowns, scepters, and further items of insignia. As I have previously devoted in-depth studies to crowns and headdresses in such contexts,[64] I will touch upon this aspect only briefly

64 Goebs, *Crowns*; also ead., 'Untersuchungen zu Funktion und Symbolgehalt des *nms*', *ZÄS* 122 (1995), 154–181.

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here—we will see a number of mentions of the White Crown in the materials presented, for example—and add a few references to further regalia and symbols of royalty, especially where they occur in conjunction with other royal terms or topoi.

Good examples are found in *CT* 16 (I, 47a–53c), which identifies the deceased as Horus with his White Crown on his head (*ḥḏt=f tp=f*); as such he 'sits before Geb'—a reference to a typical icon of coronation[65]—and is given the two staffs (*jꜣty*) by his father Osiris. In *CT* 665 (VI, 291i), further discussed below, Horus appears 'equipped (*ꜥpr(w)*) and clad (*ḏbꜣ(w)*) as *bjtj*', highlighting the importance of items of dress and paraphernalia for the royal appearance. A throne is assigned to the deceased when crossing the sky in *CT* 48 (I, 214f), then 'purity' (*ꜥbw*) is said to 'belong to the *njswt*-king'. *CT* 260 (III 378c–379a) assigns a position of king-like pre-eminence and a throne to the moon god Thoth. The White Crown goddess, a frequent association of the moon,[66] appears as an important divine entity in this text, followed by the deceased's rising as the moon god on his great throne (*ḫꜥj=j ḥr nst wrt mnḫ=j jm m Ḏḥwty*). As such he illuminates the east (*jrr ḥḏ m jꜣbt*) and the horizon dwellers serve him (*pḥr*). Similar royal associations of the moon are also found in *CT* 678 and, potentially, *CT* 660, for which see below.

3.3 *Conquest of Territory and Violent Takeover*

3.3.1 *CT* 256 (III, 365a, e) (S1C^{a,b} S2C^{a,b}, S3C)

Also *CT* 256 presents an example of cosmic rule, being entitled a 'Spell for becoming the *njswt*-king of the sky'. But the royal theme is here augmented by explicitly violent and militaristic overtones that are mobilized in the context of seizing territory. The deceased conquers (*dr*, *jtj*) the horizon with his own hand (*m ꜥ=j*), the netherworld by means of (or from) the hand of Re (*m ꜥ Rꜥw*), and the *wrrt*-crown by means of (or from) the hand of the Ennead. There follows:

CT III, 365e–366a

dy n=j njswt	the *njswt*-king
ḥr swt Ḥrw	on the thrones of Horus has been given to me,
sšr=f n=j ḫꜣꜣw /	that he may shoot down the slaughterers
(S1C^{a}: *ḫꜣwtjw*) …	for me …
jtj.n=j ꜣḫt …	I have seized the horizon …

65 See Goebs, K., 'An Elusive Passage of the Earlier Funerary Literature in its Iconographic and Ritual Context', *ZÄS* 136 (2009), 126–130.

66 Goebs, *Crowns*, 146–151.

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Here the office of *njswt* is hence explicitly linked with the act of violently seizing and thus conquering a region, and a celestial location is once again envisioned—the sky and later specifically the horizon.[67] And yet again, a celestial succession seems to be envisaged, as the former *njswt*-king 'on the thrones of Horus' appears to aid,[68] and ultimately yield to (as explicit in the spell title), the deceased in this office.

3.3.2 *CT* 678 (VI, 305g) (B1Bo)

A violent ruler is also described in *CT* 678, which assigns bloodthirsty characteristics to the deceased as *njswt*-king (*njswt pw N pn*)—he is the owner of *ꜣt*-striking power, sharp-horned (*nb ꜣt spd ḥnwty*), and said to decapitate beings without any chance of recovery (*ḥsq=f nj ṯs tp=f*). Especially the latter two associations are typical of Thoth in religious literature, where his lunar sickle is often envisaged as either a 'horn' or a 'knife' (*ds*) used to decapitate stellar beings and solar enemies.[69] In *CT* 678 these nocturnal associations are amplified by having the deceased emerge from the 'House (*pr*) of Thoth', 'who has broken up the fight' (*sḏ ꜥḥꜣ*)—a distinctive reference to this god's role in the Contendings of Horus and Seth.[70] The kingship envisioned in this spell is hence

67 This association continues an earlier Pyramid Text tradition such as expressed in PT 439 (§ 814c), where the version preserved in (P) declares that the deceased has 'seized the two lands like the *njswt*-king of the gods' (*ữtj.n NN tꜣwy m(r) njswt nṯrw*), while the later versions (M) and (N) only write *n(j)sw(t)* (cf. the writing in (N): ). For the context of the Pyramid Texts, such statements have traditionally been interpreted as attesting to the continued rule and kingship of the former king of the living in the afterlife; cf. Barta, W., *Die Bedeutung der Pyramidentexte für den verstorbenen König* (MÄS 39, Munich/Berlin, 1981), 116; Windus-Staginsky, E., *Der ägyptische König im Alten Reich: Terminologie und Phraseologie* (Wiesbaden, 2006), 38.

68 I did consider a miswriting for *nsyt* and a resulting translation 'the kingship on the thrones of Horus is given to me', but the resumptive *=f* in 366a makes this unlikely, unless it refers to Horus (in which case read: 'the king(ship) on the thrones is given to me, Horus—he shoots down …'). The meaning of the text would not be substantially altered as the deceased would appear as the successor of Horus in either case. Barguet, P., *Les Textes des Sarcophages égyptiens du moyen empire: Introduction et traduction* (Paris, 1986), 551 rendered 'Que soit donnée à moi une royauté sur le trône d'Horus …', but the absence of a proclitic and of the passive marker *.t(j/w)* in what would have to be a subjunctive construction, or, if prospective passive, of the full stem *rdy* make this meaning unlikely. See also Goebs, *Crowns*, 78–79 for this issue.

69 Violent associations of Thoth are collected, for example, by Stadler, M.A., *Weiser und Wesir. Studien zu Vorkommen, Rolle und Wesen des Gottes Thot im ägyptischen Totenbuch* (Tübingen, 2009), 328–333, 386.

70 A luni-royal scenario may be envisaged also in *CT* 660 (VI 282d) (B1Bo), where the deceased is 'a *njswt*-king forthgoing of nose' (*njswt pw pr(w) fnḏ*). Faulkner wished to see this as a metaphorical expression for someone who 'probes' things, 'pokes his nose into affairs' (*Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts* II, 232, n. 13), but in view of some passages where the

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that of the moon over the many stellar beings of the night, and rule over a group of beings is the theme of a number of other texts also.[71]

3.4 *Rule over a Multitude of Beings and Control of Provisions*

3.4.1 *CT* 195 (III, 113q) (T1L, B4C)

CT 195 presents a cosmic scenario encountered during the New Moon festival (*psḏntjw*). One of the spell's aims is to ensure the offerings and continued existence of the deceased at this time of the month. The text asserts that he is 'the *njswt*-King of those yonder' (*njswt ntjw jm*), has come before Ptah, and sits on a throne-dais at the front of the horizon (*ḥr ḏbꜣt m ḫnt ꜣḫt*). In what appears to be a mythical explanation for why the moon is absent at the New Moon, the deceased then encounters (*gm*) Khonsu standing in his path as he returns from Punt (*m hꜣt=f m pwnt*). Khonsu causes him to stand with thousands and sit with hundreds of brethren and citizens (*njwtjw*), and he eats what these gods eat. The topic in this case is therefore the nocturnal rule over the night-time, stellar, denizens of the sky (called *ntjw jm, snw, njwtjw*), which moreover entails control of provisions.[72] Also *CT* 816 (VII, 15q; T3B) describes a situation where a *njswt*-king is in charge of a group of beings that in this case seem to be in his service, however. The text is difficult to understand, but the deceased, after several references to gods such as Anubis and Sokar, addresses a group of celestial inhabitants that appear to represent the dead and are said to be the 'messengers of the *njswt*-king of death' or 'the dead' (*j ḫwnw mtw … wpwtjw njswt mt*)—

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deceased asserts that he will 'cut off the heads' of any opponents in his path, or reference to the 'knife which is on Nut', I would rather like to see the characterization as evoking an epithet of Thoth, who can be referred to as *fnḏy* in *BD* 125, for example (see Stadler, *Weiser und Wesir*, 90 with n. 158).

71 A good example is *CT* 152 (II, 260c–f; all exemplars from Bershe), which does not specify a royal context, however. The deceased addresses a request to the moon, wishing to ascend among his stellar multitude (*wr wbn m jr.ḥ … pry=j m-m ršꜣt=k tw r pt*). A similar imagery is employed in an explicitly royal context on the early 18th Dyn. stela of Ahmose (Cairo CG 3400, l. 15), which describes this king in terms of various cosmic entities. Among other associations, he is said to appear with his archers by his side 'like the moon in the midst of the stars' (*mj jr.ḥ ḥrj-jb sbꜣw*). For this stela see most recently Stauder, A., *Linguistic dating of Middle Egyptian Literary Texts*, vol. 2 (Lingua Aegyptia Studia Monographica 12, Hamburg, 2013), 431–433.

72 The New Moon (*psḏntjw*) is associated with night-time inhabitants of the sky (here *ḥḥw*—millions and *ḫnmmt*—sunfolk) and provisions also in the Coffin Text version of the Cannibal Spell, *CT* 573 (VI, 179j–k); see Goebs, *Crowns*, 211, 216, 245 with commentary and further literature. The lunar phase between *psḏntjw* and the Full Moon is the period of renewal within the Egyptian belief system, and offerings are most often presented in this period (Wallin, P., *Celestial Cycles. Astronomical Concepts of Regeneration in the Ancient Egyptian Coffin Texts* (Uppsala Studies in Egyptology 1, Uppsala, 2002), 75–89, esp. pp. 87–89).

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Osiris is most likely meant yet again. The same identification seems to apply in *CT* 189 (III, 97i; B9C, B1L): here the deceased himself identifies as the '*njswt*-king of those yonder' (*ntjw jm*) in the context of asserting his right to provisions, a barque, and access to the sky.[73]

3.5 *Serving Royalty*

Within the Coffin Texts presented up to this point, the use of royal concepts associated with the deceased is arguably not all that different from what we would expect to find in the Pyramid Texts—the associations can perhaps be said to be somewhat more explicit and comprehensive, presenting longer descriptions and elaborations, and at times including certain references or formal characteristics that are not yet attested in the earlier corpus (as particularly explicit in *CT* 313, for example).[74] The idea of identifying or associating the deceased with one of the typical kings or rulers of the sky (or a particular area therein), is the same, however. There are a number of spells in the Coffin Texts that, instead of asserting the royalty of the deceased, present him in the favor of—and thus dependent on—a 'king', however. An excellent example is *CT* 257.

3.5.1 *CT* 257 (III, 367a) (B2L, B3C); (III, 370c) (B1C)[75] / (III, 369a) (B3C; S1C$^{b, c}$, S2C$^{a, b}$, S3C)

This spell is entitled 'To become an honoured one of the *njswt*-king of the sky' (*jm3ḫy n njswt pt*) on three coffins from Bershe; the theme is picked up again within the text proper when the deceased asks that a path be prepared for him, and apparently aims to attain extra impact by justifying his request with the statement that he is an *jm3ḫy*-honoured one of this celestial *njswt*-king. Interestingly, there is some variation in the different versions at this point, with S1C^{a} inserting *Ḫnsw*, 'Khonsu' instead.[76] This luni-royal entity is the source, or basis, from which the deceased then sets out to reach his position next to Ra in the midst of the sky (*jw pr(=j) m r3=f r-gs Rˁw* (S1C^{a}, ^{c}: *ˁḥˁ* (*=j*)) *m ḥrj-jb pt*). In

73 Similar aspirations of the deceased are already encountered in the Pyramid Texts, where they may also be connected with holding the titles *njswt-bjtj* or *bjtj*. Thus, *PT* 426 § 776a–b (P) asserts that the deceased is risen as *njswt-bjtj* because he is *sḫm*-powerful over the gods and their kas (*ḫˁj.n=k m njswt-bjtj n sḫm=k m nṯrw kȝw=sn jsṯ*); similar *PT* 592 § 1626 (M).

74 See Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, 'The Role of Osiris in the Mythological cycle devised around Heracleopolis Magna', with n. 17 for summary and earlier literature.

75 The reference to the *njswt*-king here appears in the spell title, which is attested for the Bershe coffins only and on B1C is continued at the end of the spell.

76 B2L and B1C—despite having the correct spell title—miswrite *njswt* as *snt*, 'sister' but use the masculine resumptive pronoun in the ensuing clause.

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other words, the *njswt*-king of the sky is once again a divine entity that marks a particular cosmic situation—whether the mention of Khonsu in S1C[a] is a misunderstanding or rather serves to indicate that those two entities are to be seen as identical is unclear, but the deceased can emerge from this being into the celestial realm and right next to the Sun god. Most informative for our examination of the concept of royalty in the Coffin Texts is, however, that the deceased does not claim the kingship for himself here. Rather, he adopts a position that would have seemed much more appropriate for a high official, and one that he would have used many times in his life and in his other funerary inscriptions, such as his tomb autobiography and offering formulae, namely that of *jm3ḫy ḥr njswt*.[77] Both associations seem to have fulfilled the same purpose in this corpus, which is expressed explicitly in the title of the ensuing spell, *CT* 258:[78] *tm sk ḏt*, 'Not to perish, ever'.

3.5.2 *CT* 531 (VI, 125f) (M16C, M35C, M36C, M2Ann.)

A similar dependence on, or inferiority to, the celestial king is expressed in *CT* 531, where the deceased seems to appear as Horus,[79] helper of Osiris, whom Re gave to Osiris to end the injury by Seth and assist him in a variety of ways to ensure that he arrive in the realm of the dead safe and sound. In line with the patterns observed in several of the spells discussed, the deceased also displays clear characteristics of Osiris himself. Within an enumeration of his divinized limbs according to the patterns of a 'Gliedervergottung'[80] his White Crown is identified as Thoth,[81] which suggests a broadly nocturnal setting. Eventually we read:

77 This status is explicit also in *CT* 803 (VII, 9p; L2Li), where a rather damaged section appears to refer to the deceased as *Wsjr N jm3ḫ ˁnj'swt*. Even though all other mentions of the deceased's name in this spell do not sport this specification, this particular example of *jm3ḫy*, as well as those in *CT* 826 (VII, 27n, (o)), should probably be understood as part of the (post-mortem) name of the deceased without any mythological significance.

78 Follows *CT* 257 on most of the coffins from Assiut.

79 He is referred to with the epithet *nfr ḥr*, which is commonly used for this god but also for Ptah and Osiris; on the epithet see e.g. Spiegelberg, W., 'Die Bedeutung von *nfr-ḥr*', *ZÄS* 53 (1917), 115; Altenmüller, B., *Synkretismus in den Sargtexten* (GOF IV/7, Wiesbaden, 1975), 278 for refs.; see Goebs, *Crowns*, 147–148 for discussion of this text and additional arguments in favor of identifying the deity in question as Horus in this context.

80 For which see e.g. Quack, J., 'Dekane und Gliedervergottung: Altägyptische Traditionen im Apokryphon Johannis', *JAC* 38 (1995), 97–122; also Assmann and Bommas, *Totenliturgien* 1, 179–188; Nyord, *Breathing Flesh*, 510–522, with further lit.

81 For use of the White Crown in this text, and of its lunar connotations, see e.g. Goebs, *Crowns*, 147–152.

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jw wḏ.n njswt	The *njswt*-king has ordered
smꜣ-ḫrw (M36C adds: *jmꜣḫy*) *N pn*	that N be justified (and honoured)
r ḥftiw=f ḫr Ḥrw nb pḥt.	against his enemies before Horus *nb pḥt.*

The ultimate aim of the spell, explicit only in M36C, is once again that the deceased endure in the sky (*mn*) like Re forever.

We have two possibilities of understanding the reference to the *njswt*-king here. It may function as an indicator of the coffin owner's continued status as an official in royal employ, dependent on his king and lord in death as he was in life, or else the title may once again designate a specific celestial deity, ruling a portion of the daily cosmic cycle. The former situation may be envisaged in *CT* 472 (VI, 1i; B2L, B1P), for example, where the deceased takes possession of his thrones as powerful lord over his shabtis and is beheld as ruler among his 'herds'[82] (*jtj.n=f n=f nswt=f ḥqꜣ.n=f m ꜥwt*). If he were to be called to work—including various aspects of agricultural or other manual labour—'for the current *njswt*-king' (*n njswt jmj hꜣw=f*), the shabtis will respond on his behalf. In other words: while the deceased holds the role of an enthroned leader or sovereign in this text, reference is made also to a *njswt*-king who considers him a subject, one who might require him to do manual labor. Two different conceptions, or uses, of ruler- or kingship seem to be colliding in *CT* 472, therefore, with one potentially referring to an actually reigning monarch whom the deceased would have encountered in his lifetime, and the other expressing his wish to be in control of his own afterlife by adopting a position of regal dominance. The latter conception attests to a quasi-metaphorical use of the terminology of rule, and I will return to this point later.

In the case of *CT* 531, by contrast, it is more likely that *njswt* refers to a specific celestial ruler, since Horus *nb pḥt* is an explicitly celestial god in other contexts.[83] Such a situation seems to be envisaged also in *CT* 279 (IV, 26j; T1L, Sq6C), where the relevant section is much damaged. The deceased appears to arrive in the west, where he receives provisions and 'settles' or 'proceeds' (*sḫn*) in the presence of the *njswt*-king; further in spells such as *CT* 484 (VI, 60c, B1Bo), where the deceased plainly wishes to be 'in the retinue of the *njswt*-king of the sky' (*jw N m šmsw njswt pt*).[84] We have seen Osiris designated plainly as '*njswt*' in a number of spells and this is the most likely interpretation of the royal figure also in these three cases.

82 Which Faulkner (*Coffin Texts* II, 107 n. 5) wished to understand as a metaphor referring to his human subjects.

83 Goebs, *Crowns*, 38–39; see also Altenmüller, *Synkretismus*, 39.

84 Similar also *CT* 926 (VII, 129g; M2C), mostly concerned with ritual provisions: the deceased

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3.5.3 *CT* 317 (IV 125b—*njswt*) (S1P, S1C, S2C); (IV, 113a—*bjtj*) (S1P, S1C, S3C)

CT 317, a spell about Hapi's important role in the Egyptian cosmos, displays some ambiguity in its application of royal concepts. In version S1P the deceased as Hapi comes 'to the *njswt*-king' (*n njswt*) in his dignity (*sʿḥ*) and power (*sḫm*), while version S1C makes Hapi himself into a *njswt*-king (*m njswt*) and endows him with royal insignia—*sḫm*-scepter and *sʿḥ*-dignity. Clearly Egyptian *n* and *m* are easily and often confused, so a miswriting is likely. S1P's version, which presents Hapi in a somewhat secondary position, seems to be borne out by another part of the same text, which moreover presents one of the only four attestations for *bjtj* in the Coffin Texts. There the deceased as Hapi is the one who delivers offerings and provisions to the *bjtj*-king, who is moreover the ruler (?) of the island of flames (*jnk jn(w) ḥtpw dfꜣw n bjtj pw ⸢ḥqꜣ⸣*[85] *jw ns(r)sr*). This setting conveys a scenario of sunrise,[86] and the deceased later switches identities to present himself as Khepri. I would therefore like to see the *bjtj* as referring to Atum as solar creator here. *Sꜣty bjtj*, 'The twins of the *bjtj*', is a common epithet of this god's first offspring, Shu and Tefnet.[87] Similar to the frequent use of '*njswt*' as a generic term for Osiris[88] also '*bjtj*' seems to have denoted a specific

rises 'in the following of the *njswt*' (*ḫʿ.tj m šmsw njswt*); in *CT* 557 (VI, 158k), the deceased arrives to see Osiris—later in the spell 'the *njswt*-king descends'; in *CT* 629 (VI, 250e; S10C[b]) he has to report to 'yonder monarch' (*jty ntj jm*)—likely yet another reference to Osiris.

85 See de Buck, *Coffin Texts* IV, 113 n. 1*; *bjtj* unusually determined with the seated god wearing a White Crown.

86 Abbas, E.S., *The Lake of Knives and the Lake of Fire: Studies in the Topography of Passage in Ancient Egyptian Religious Literature* (BAR IS 2144, Oxford, 2010).

87 Thus for example in *CT* 80 (II, 32f–g); see already Kees, H., *Der Götterglaube im alten Ägypten* (Leipzig, 1941), 176 n. 4; also Goebs, *Crowns*, 53 with n. 82 for further lit., and Windus-Staginsky, *Der ägyptische König im Alten Reich*, 46–47, for attestations of the royal title *bjtj* in the Pyramid Texts, most of which pertain to the construction *sꜣty bjtj*.

88 *CT* 888 (VII, 100f; S10C) exceptionally appears to present *njswt* as a generic term for the sun god on his celestial journey, however. Here 'the *njswt*-king is on the water' (that is, has embarked on his voyage), followed by a warning not to oppose the movements of Re in his *wsḫt*-hall (*njswt ḥr mw jm=k jw ḫsf=k šmwt Rʿw m wsḫt=f*). Barguet (*Textes des sarcophages*, 44) rather translated 'le roi est obéissant', which renders poor sense. *CT* 947 (VII, 163l; pGard. III) has 'traps' (*sʿḫ ʾwt*) or 'foundations' (*sʿnṯ ʾwt*) of (or among?), the *njsw*(*t*)-kings (or perhaps rather read *nsjw*, 'fiery ones'?) set up for the deceased as Wadjit, likely evoking a sunrise scenario. These beings would then refer to the night-time inhabitants of the sky. For a fish-net or -trap as a metaphor for the dawn light in which the stars are trapped and disappear at sunrise see Goebs, *Crowns*, 220, 257–261: fish and bird are manifestations that a star displays in the course of his life and journey from the *dwꜣt* to the sky and back, while a 'fishing net of Wadjit', which is stretched out between sky and earth, is described in *CT* 474 (VI, 17b, g), for example.

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mythical (and celestial) actor in some contexts, therefore. A similar pattern can be observed for *jry-pʿt*, which, as noted, is near exclusive to Geb in the Coffin Texts.

Returning to the discussion of *njswt*, it is of interest that two versions of the same spell would consider either the *njswt*-kingship of the Nile god himself or else his serving the *njswt*-king as perfectly good and effective associations to evoke in a funerary context. And indeed, being of assistance to a deity or king is a common theme in the Coffin Texts. A particularly important god in these texts is Thoth, who, besides appearing in a royal position himself as we saw in *CT* 678, for example, is invoked as a helper in several spells that have as their theme the correct succession of rulers. We already encountered Thoth in this role in *CT* 313.

3.5.4 *CT* 314 (IV, 94a) (B5C)[89]

The deceased first identifies himself, yet again, as the *njswt*-king Osiris (*jnk Wsjr kꜣ jmntt njswt jwtjw*) but later adopts the role of his helper in the tribunal vindicating Osiris against his enemies (*jnk wʿ m ḏꜣḏꜣt nt smꜣʿ-ḥrw Wsjr r ḫftjw=f*). He then specifies further aspects of his role: As the god whom Nut bore he slew the foes of Osiris and imprisoned those who rebelled against him. He also belongs in the company of Horus, however, and has vindicated Horus against his foes on the day of judgment in the *ḥwt sr* of Heliopolis.[90] While the text does not present a straightforward narrative sequence or singular mythological role of the deceased, his primary identification is clearly with Thoth, who plays a fundamental role in the vindication of both Osiris and Horus.[91] The spell accordingly ends by asserting that the successful transfer of rule is due to him—it is he 'who established (or confirmed) the inheritance of the throne of the two shores for the son of its lord' (*smn jwʿt nst jdbwy n sꜣ nb jry*). In choosing this particular association for the deceased, the text's author moreover picked a

89 Note that this text follows on *CT* 313, with no obvious break between the two, but represents a separate chapter in the Book of the Dead, *BD* 1.

90 The mythical location where, among other things, the kingship was transferred to its rightful owner; see Goebs, *Crowns*, 73 with nn. 136–137.

91 This mytheme is transmitted in a direct line from the Coffin Texts, via the Book of the Dead—in chapters such as *BD* 18—into the Roman Period, where it is still found, for example, in the so-called *First Letter for Breathing*, a kind of 'passport' to enter the afterlife attested mostly in Theban tombs of the Ptolemaic and Roman eras. See e.g. Herbin, F.R., *Books of Breathing and Other Related Texts* (Catalogue of the Books of the Dead and Other Religious Texts in the British Museum IV, London, 2008), 50–52, 60; Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, *Naref*, 59–61; see also Stadler, *Weiser und Wesir*, 327–341. Within the Coffin Texts, *CT* 339 (esp. IV, 338 ff.) is particularly important.

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central and conspicuous actor of the nocturnal cycle as his mythical role model. Other spells evoke such nighttime scenarios by means of different mythical deputies.

3.5.5 *CT* 647 (VI, 268i) (G1T)

A nocturnal stage is the backdrop also in *CT* 647, where the deceased adopts the role of Ptah (-Nehebkau), who in this text appears as a nighttime deputy of the sun god. As such he is 'foremost' of the land (*ḥry-tp tꜣ*), scribe of the *pr-wr*, as well as in charge of justice in the tribunal and of order in the solar barque. He has creative faculties—causing fields to green for all humankind—and, as Nehebkau, grants bas and kas as well as appearings (or crowns, *ḫ-w*) to the gods in a clear reference to the nightly appearance of stellar deities in the sky. This time-frame is underscored by reference to his steering the night-barque. His royal associations include being called the celestial denizens' monarch (*jty nṯrw*), 'ruling' or 'presiding over' (*sr*) the two lands and being the '*njswt*-king of the sky'. I have elsewhere suggested that Ptah is here in the role of the nocturnal creator (of the celestial gods, the stars), but as such is dependent on, and ultimately serves, the solar creator god.[92] Ludwig Morenz, by contrast, wishes to see certain parts of *CT* 647[93] as an 'eigenständigen Mikrotext' that in his view proves the local (re-)shaping of certain Coffin Text spells. He interprets this text as an adaptation of a scene attested in a chapel of Hathor built at Gebelein by Mentuhotep II, hypothesizing that both sources are in fact based on a hymn to that king—but for which, as Morenz admits, there is no proof.[94] While the royal associations of Ptah preserved in this spell are to date singular in the surviving Coffin Texts, this god is commonly attested with royal attributes in later periods[95] and the materials presented in the present study demonstrate unequivocally that royal associations of solar deputies—be they presented as Osiris, Horus, Thoth, Ruty,[96] or Ptah—are commonplace in this corpus. Constructing a hypothetical, direct, derivation of these concepts from royal sources

92 Goebs, *Crowns*, 70, 331–333; for Ptah as secondary deity and son of the solar creator in the Coffin Texts see also Bickel, S., *La cosmogonie égyptienne avant le nouvel empire* (OBO 134, Fribourg/Göttingen, 1994), 137–145, esp. pp. 140, 144.

93 Esp. *CT* VI, 268c–g, the section preceding the clause containing *njswt*.

94 Morenz, L., *Die Zeit der Regionen im Spiegel der Gebelein-Region: Kulturgeschichtliche Re-Konstruktionen* (Leiden/Boston, 2010), 447–454; the relief from Mentuhotep II's hathoric chapel comprises fragments Cairo 24/5/28/5 (for which see ibid., fig. 7).

95 *Njswt tꜣwy* is one of the commonest epithets of Ptah in the New Kingdom; see Sandman Holmberg, M., *The God Ptah* (Lund, 1946), 83.

96 *CT* 438 (V, 290f); see below, n. 102.

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outside of the funerary sphere is hence unnecessary, even though such cross-fertilization is not in itself implausible.[97]

3.5.6 *CT* 665 (VI, 291i) (B1Bo) (*bjtj*)

Within the Coffin Text materials I examined for this study, *CT* 665 is most expressive in assigning a potentially secondary role to the deceased. It explicitly ascribes the position of scribe to him.[98] Moreover, this text offers another one of the only four attestations of *bjtj* in this corpus. It is Horus who is labelled thus—arguably in reference to the Lower Egyptian kingship associated specifically with this god in several contexts,[99] and in iconography and visual language expressed by attributing to the holder of the title the Red Crown (*dšrt* or *nt*).[100] Within the Coffin texts, a geographical signification of the Red Crown of the *bjtj* is perhaps signaled in *CT* 42 (I, 178p, 179a, B3Bo, B2Bo), where the dual kingship of the *njswt-bjtj* is associated with the White and Red Crowns.[101] These appear as the 'white Eye of Horus' (*jrt Ḥrw ḥḏt*) and, unusually, as what appears to be the 'Khemmis Eye of Horus' (*jrt Ḥrw ꜣḫt-bjtj*(*t*)) on coffin B2Bo. This link between the Red Crown and Khemmis alludes to the Lower Egyptian rule of

97 See also Goebs, *Crowns*, esp. pp. 375–378, where I discuss some of the problems associated with this issue and suggest that the process can work in both directions.

98 See also Nyord, R., 'Scribes of the Gods in the Coffin Texts', in Miniaci, G. and Grajetzki, W. (eds.), *The World of Middle Kingdom Egypt (2000–1550 BC): Contributions on Archaeology, Art, Religion, and Written Sources* (Middle Kingdom Studies I, London, 2015), 273–308, who presents evidence not only for the deceased identifying as a scribe or other administrator of gods such as Atum, Re, Hathor, or Thoth, but also for his acknowledging his subservient role to these deities. For *CT* 665 see his p. 286.

99 The so-called Memphite Theology on the Shabaqa Stone is particularly explicit on this point. For an easily accessible English translation see e.g. Lichtheim, M., *Ancient Egyptian Literature: A Book of Readings* I, *The Old and Middle Kingdoms* (Berkeley, etc., 1973), 51–57 (where the text is dated to the Old Kingdom, however); passage in question on p. 52 l. 8. Recent analysis now in El-Hawary, A., *Wortschöpfung: Die Memphitische Theologie und die Siegesstele des Pije—Zwei Zeugen kultureller Repräsentation in der 25. Dynastie* (OBO 243, Fribourg/Göttingen, 2010).

100 Hatshepsut's famous coronation sequence, preserved on the so-called Chapelle Rouge at Karnak, is particularly explicit: During her coronation with the Red Crown (block 145), Amun-Re asserts that with this crown he bestows on her the 'dignity (or role, *sꜥḥ*) of *bjtj*' (Burgos, F. and Larché, F., *La chapelle rouge: Le sanctuaire de barque d'Hathsepsout* I (Éditions Recherche sur les Civilisations), Paris, 2006–2008, 82). The association is also present in funerary literature, where already *PT* 412 § 724b states that the Red Crown (*nt*) belongs to the *bjtj*; cf. Goebs, *Crowns*, 166–167. See also above, n. 10, for literature on some divergent interpretations of *bjtj*.

101 Note that this is a further spell that Faulkner, *Coffin Texts* I, 35 n. 1 wished to see as originating in the coronation ritual of kings, remarking that in it the deceased appears to be 'quite unmistakably promoted to royal rank'.

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Horus, who was nursed in this location before appearing as legitimate ruler.[102] Notably, *CT* 42 is moreover the only spell in the corpus that employs the title *njswt-bjtj*.[103] In line with the use of several royal terms discussed so far it is attributed to Osiris on the throne of Geb, and with Horus as his heir.

Returning to *CT* 665, we see a cosmic scenario rolled out also here:

CT VI, 291i–t

jy Ḥrw ꜥpr(w) ḏbꜣ(w) m bjtj[104]	Horus arrives, equipped and clad as *bjtj*,[105]
smnᵣ=fᵣ Wsjr	that he may install / establish Osiris
m st=f ḥrw=f pw n ḥꜥw	(…) in his place on this his day of the accession. (…)
N sš=f Qnqnwy rn(=f) (…)	N is his scribe, Kenkenwy by name. (…)
jw ꜥr=f m sḫm	his pen is (as) a *sḫm*-sceptre,
dj swꜣ=f	which causes that he move forward/passes on,
jry=f jrw	'He will perform deeds
jry=f sšmw	and achieve leadership (or: do errands?)'
j.jn Wsjr r N pn	—so says Osiris of this N.

Later, Osiris asks Re-Atum to let his son, the deceased, pass at the head of all the gods in their places and duties.

In this case Horus hence establishes Osiris on his throne, which may imply yet another changeover of power and, at the same time, refers to Horus's role as helper of his father after his death. As regards the role of the *bjtj* in this

102 Already the Pyramid Texts state that Horus/the deceased 'comes forth from (*prj m*) Pe' when he takes over his rule (e.g. *PT* 555), see Goebs, *Crowns*, 121ff., 165. Assumption of the throne and exercising the kingship in Khemmis is found also in *CT* 438 (V, 290f, B3Bo), where this role is ascribed to (the deceased as) Ruty, however, who is here said to be both in charge of the solar journey of Atum and come into being as Re every day.

103 *CT* 695 (VI, 129g) may present a garbled writing of the title (see n. 29 above). If so, it refers to a group of inhabitants of the horizon here.

104 Title determined with the seated king with White Crown here; see also *CT* 317 (IV, 113a)—above 88 with n. 85.

105 The reference to a particular dress and crown associated with the title of *bjtj* has, besides Hatshepsut's coronation (n. 100), another parallel in the biography of the 5th Dynasty Sem-priest Rawer (*Urk.* I, 232), who has left us a rare account of a royal blunder. This occurred during the ritual of seizing the prow-rope of the (divine) barque, when the king's scepter came into contact with Rawer's leg and, potentially, made him stumble and fall—interpretations vary on this point (see e.g. Allen, J.P., 'Re'wer's accident', in Lloyd, A.B. (ed.), *Studies in Pharaonic Religion and Society in Honour of J. Gwyn Griffiths* (EES Occasional Publication 8, London, 1992), 14–20). For our purposes it is of note that king Neferirkare had 'appeared as *bjtj*' (*ḫꜥw m bjtj*) for this ritual, implying a particular royal role and set of paraphernalia.

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text—the exact meaning of this title remaining, as indicated, disputed in the field[106]—we can confirm the royal connotations of the title for the present text due to the mention of the day of the accession. Either the enthronement of Horus or that of Osiris could be referred to here.

Most interesting for our purposes is, however, the fact that the deceased presents himself as an employee and assistant of Osiris in this spell, rather than as the 'king of the sky'. His pen is his claim to fame and power,[107] and it appears to be his effective administrative skills that ensure his place in the hereafter. While there are already a couple of instances of the deceased taking on the role of scribe or administrator of the sun god in the Pyramid Texts, this particular theme is distinctly more widespread, and covered in a much more nuanced fashion, in the Coffin Texts, illustrating another instance of developing funerary beliefs between the Old and Middle Kingdoms.[108]

4 Conclusion: Use and Significance of the Concepts 'Royalty' and 'Myth' in the Coffin Texts

The materials presented in this study show that royal designators in the Coffin Texts normally appear within mythical contexts and are used to describe:
- Authority over a region
- Authority over a group of people (or other beings)
- Authority over resources

The office they designate is in most cases:
- Attributed to a mythical actor who inherits it from a predecessor
- This entity yields it willingly at his own demise or abdication—however one wishes to interpret the setting of a personified celestial body such as the sun in mythical terms. In most cases, the succession is one from Geb to Osiris and from Osiris to Horus, although a few other 'kings' feature in the funerary literature, such as Ptah, Atum, Thoth, or Ruty. These deities ultimately act as 'deputies' of Re.

106 For example, Kahl, '*nsw* und *bỉt*: die Anfänge' (cf. n. 10 above), wishes to see *bjtj* as describing the aspect of the ruler in charge of collecting and redistributing goods. *CT* spells such as *CT* 317 (discussed above, pp. 88–89), where the title appears in conjunction with reference to the Island of Fire, suggest certain creative and cosmic associations in the funerary literature.

107 See Nyord, 'Scribes of the Gods', 276 for the important role of scribal implements in such texts.

108 Schott, S., 'Schreiber und Schreibgerät im Jenseits', *JEA* 54 (1968), 45–50; Nyord, 'Scribes of the Gods in the Coffin Texts', 273–274.

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– In some instances rule is under threat and/or is taken by force.
– Assumption of the office is in several cases connected with the adoption of supernatural powers and of items of insignia symbolizing and channeling these, such as thrones, crowns, scepters, or particular garments, which may be viewed as divine and can be personified.[109]

All of these aspects correspond to the characteristics typically associated with 'Kingship' or a 'Monarchy' in the above-cited encyclopedias.

In the Coffin Texts, the deceased either identifies with the mythical actors holding the cited royal position and its prerogatives and paraphernalia, or presents himself in close association with them. In some cases, he assumes an explicitly subservient position, however, most notably in the spells that present him as an *jmꜣḫw*[110] or scribe of another (normally divine) king. His identification with royal 'target figures'[111] hence alternates, or is intermixed, with his embodying non-royal ones so that the royal signification cannot be cited as a primary concern of these texts.

What is more, in the majority of cases the use of royal associations in the Coffin Texts clearly serves a purpose outside of a narrowly defined royal realm. This is perhaps most explicit in a few examples where the royal terminology is simply used to express control, or power, over something or someone. Thus *CT* 83 (II, 47a), one of the Shu spells, describes the deceased as an *ꜣḫ jqr njswt n ṯꜣw nb n pt*, 'Excellent/effective *ꜣḫ*, King of all the winds of the sky'.[112] Most importantly, however, in most texts the purpose of evoking the respective royal associations is plainly to ensure continued life and dominance of the deceased beneficiary in a celestial setting, where the model of the terrestrial royal succession is employed to guarantee an existence over the full length of the cosmic cycle, with all its different parts.[113] One may even go so far as to say that the concepts of Royalty or Kingship are ultimately employed metaphorically in these texts, intended to express this desired state of affairs in an easily comprehensible, yet magically effective manner. In English we may think of common expressions such as 'I'm the king of the road', or 'my home is my castle', to better understand such a metaphorical use of royal terminology. In the Coffin Texts,

109 Particularly common for the crowns—see e.g. Goebs, *Crowns*, 175–203.

110 Here it is of note that the status of *jmꜣḫ* appears only once in the Pyramid Texts, in *PT* 535 § 1289a of Pepi I, where it occurs in the compound *wtwtj jmꜣḫ* 'revered eldest son', however (see *TLA* lemma-no. 51130 for *wtwtj*).

111 Translating Assmann's 'Zielgestalten'; see n. 37 above.

112 The royal reference only on the Bershe coffins: B1C, B2L, B1P, B7C.

113 'Involvement in cyclical regeneration' is also cited by Nyord as one of the most important concerns of Coffin Texts identifying the deceased as a scribe of a deity ('Scribes of the Gods in the Coffin Texts', 287).

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the metaphorical complexes employed are ultimately derived from myths—and here of course in particular the royal myths, with those of the Osirian cycle being the most important.

Already in the Pyramid Texts, certain deities from this mythical complex appear as 'the king', a royal entity par excellence: Thus Horus is *njswt nṯrw* in *PT* 570 (§1458e P, M) while *PT* 650 §§1833a–b (N) equates the deceased with Osiris (*Wsjr pw N pn*), born by Nut, who causes him to shine forth as *njswt-bjtj* (*N pn ms(w) n Nwt sḫʿj.n=s sw m njswt-bjtj m sʿḥ=f nb*). Osiris also appears as the son of Geb in this spell so that the typical sequence of legitimate successors is presented. When *PT* 542 §1335b (P) (however its exact meaning is to be interpreted) speaks of the travelling of the *njswt*-king past the places of Anubis (*nʿj njswt ḥr swt Jnpw*), it is difficult not to think of a Osirian figure; also *PT* 486 §§1041a–1042d (N), which seems to describe a judgment scenario potentially resulting in the seizing and sentencing of the deceased by a court composed of *njswt*-king and *srw*-offcials, seems to fit into this mythical complex. Since the deceased is part of the primordial Helioplitan corporation (*wʿ n ḫt twʿꜣt msyt m bꜣḥ m Jwnw*) he will not be seized and taken away, and his enemies will not be found justified against him (*nj jṯw NN n njswt nj šdw NN n srw nj mꜣʿ-ḫrw ḫftjw=f jr=f*).[114] And where Pepi I is said not to 'slander (*šnṯ*) the *njswt*-king', he is clearly speaking of someone other than himself (*PT* 467 §892a).

However, some Pyramid Texts convey a rather unmediated use of royal titles and terminology and, by extension, highlight the royal origin of the texts in question. Thus, one of Wenis' versions of *PT* 23 §16a simply asserts that Osiris should seize all those 'who hate the *njswt*-king' where all later attestations insert the actual name of the deceased king written in a cartouche—hence attesting to the practice of personalization of an explicitly royal *Vorlage*-text. *PT* 435 §§786a–787b sets the deceased Pepi I in relation to Nut, who 'calls' (*njs*) him to herself by enumerating all of his titles and epithets, including that of *njswt-bjtj ppj*.[115] Such cases throw into relief that, while mythical and

114 For a (somewhat outdated) early history of the judgment of the dead see Grieshammer, R., *Das Jenseitsgericht in den Sargtexten* (Wiesbaden, 1970), 2–10; esp. p. 4 with n. 13 for discussions of potential Pyramid Text evidence; for the importance of legal aspects in the Osiris myth see now also Díaz-Iglesias Llanos, *Naref and Osiris-Naref*, 82–104. Identification of the *njswt* as Osiris in this context must remain conjectural, of course; reading the passage as a reference to a this-worldly royal court (model) is equally possible.

115 This text is somewhat unusual, in that it incorporates the titulary of Pepi written in much larger signs than those found on the rest of the wall. There have been a number of rather different interpretations of it, with scholars being puzzled in particular by the determinative of a group following the name of Nut, which in transcriptions appears similar to O51—the granary. Both Faulkner (*Pyramid Texts*, 143) and Allen (*Pyramid Texts*, 104), fol-

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metaphorical uses of royal terminology played a role already in the Pyramid Texts, essential parts of this corpus express a concern with retaining the Old Kingdom king's divine status in the afterlife. Such aspirations may then have led to the more mythical spells such as *PT* 548 §§1343a–b (P) and *PT* 697 §2169b (N), which relate the resurrection of the deceased and his being accepted by Geb to the fact that he is 'great like a *njswt*-king and distinguished like (or as) Re' (*wr.t(j) mr njswt swt.t(j) m(r) Rʿw*),[116] or the above-cited PT 439 §814c, which has the deceased 'seize the two lands like the king of gods' (P), or simply 'like a king' (M + N).

In light of the many mythical references cited so far, the proposed metaphorical approach to some of the 'royal' materials in the Coffin Texts may perhaps also shed some new light on the question of the use and significance of myth in the corpus. The myths employed appear, as many a scholar has noted, in no coherent format, and certainly do not display a 'beginning and an end' or a rootedness in time and space that some authors have postulated as inalienable characteristics of myth proper.[117] Neither do they present a coherent storyline or theology, even within the various snippets that are used. Solar deities and those of the Osirian cycle appear mixed together and in varying genealogical relationships, and the divine associations of the deceased change repeatedly within the same text. All of this, I submit, is consistent with interpreting them, at least on one level of their meaning and use, as metaphors (or metaphor-

lowing *Wb*. 2, 146.13, decided to see (an otherwise unattested) word *msnṯt* 'granary' here. I think that the use of signs normally used to write one of Nut's typical epithets, *ms(t) nṯ(rw)* is likely no coincidence, and that the group may designate Nut not as a 'granary' but rather a different type of 'container'—namely one from which the sungod and other deities, including the reborn king, emerge. In later texts, such as the magical Berlin papyrus 3027 for the protection of mother and child, Nut can be both *mst nṯrw* and a *sḫḏt*-box 'in which all gods are' (*sḫḏt … wnnt nṯr nb jm=s*; pBerlin P. 3027, vs. l. 5,2–3).

116 Conceivably, *njswt* could also refer to a particular mythical actor like Horus or Osiris here, as potentially underpinned by the divine determinative in *PT* 697 §2169b (N)  . See Windus-Staginsky, *Der ägyptische König im Alten Reich*, 37–39 for further attestations of *njswt* in the Pyramid Texts; the author maintains, however, that, in most instances, the title *njswt* as used in the Pyramid Texts refers to the deceased king.

117 Thus the arguments advanced in particular by Jan Assmann ('Die Verborgenheit des Mythos in Ägypten', *GM* 25 (1977), 7–43 (esp. 21); reprinted in id., *Ägyptische Geheimnisse* (Munich, 2004), 31–57), but later somewhat modified in publications such as Assmann, A. and J. Assmann, 'Mythos', in: Cancik, H. et al. (eds), *Handbuch religionswissenschaftlicher Grundbegriffe*, vol. 4 (Stuttgart/Berlin/Cologne, 1998), 179–200. For summaries of the Egyptological 'myth problem' see e.g. Goebs, K., 'A Functional Approach to Egyptian Myth and Mythemes', *JANER* 2 (2002), 227–259, esp. pp. 227–238; Stadler, *Weiser und Wesir*, 54–63, Goebs., K. and Baines, J., 'Egyptian Myth', in Roeder, H. and S. Michels (eds), *Handbuch Ägyptische Religion* (Leiden, in press).

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ical complexes) as defined in the discipline of Cognitive Linguistics. There, metaphor-formation and use is the process of understanding and describing one domain in terms of another; it consists of a set of conceptual correspondences between two conceptual domains—a source and a target.[118] In our case the desire to express (and thus realize) eternal celestial life is described in terms of a never-ending royal succession of celestial (and, for the Egyptians, divine and thus mythical) actors. Interestingly, the most important kingship designator known from the terrestrial, political sphere—*njswt bitj*—plays no role in these texts, perhaps supporting the point I am trying to make.[119] Moreover, in some cases, as we have seen, the deceased quite happily submits to an entity wielding such royal powers and wishes to appear as his *jmɜḫw* or even scribe. This state of affairs underlines more clearly than anything else that the primary purpose of these texts was not the expression of royalty—on the model of an old, exclusive, privilege—but rather that of ensuring eternal life. In this interpretation, funerary texts employing such royal and mythical themes can be used by both royal and non-royal persons, although the fact remains that our earliest attestations of such associations pertain to the often explicitly royal world of the Pyramid Texts.[120] However, as indicated, certain innovations are introduced in the Coffin Texts. Besides the marked proliferation of spells expressing the deceased's desire to be a scribe or administrator of the gods we observe a manifest predilection for dialogue, for example, and both these developments may perhaps be taken to reflect the identity, status, and tastes of the Middle Kingdom users commissioning them.[121] At the same time, other new compositions entering the corpus involve conspicuously royal elements, such as spells assigning an important role to the Atef-crown as an item of insignia pertaining to both Osiris and Horus (and, by extension, the deceased). This crown is to date not attested in the Pyramid Texts, suggesting

118 E.g. Kövecses, Z., *Metaphor in Culture: Universality and Variation* (Cambridge/New York, 2005), 26; Feldman, J.A., *From Molecule to Metaphor: A Neural Theory of Language* (Cambridge, Mass, 2008), 194.

119 The Pyramid Texts contain five references to the deceased as *njswt-bjtj*, of which two describe a scenario of celestial rebirth—*PT* 650 §1833a–b (N) and *PT* 435 §786a–787b, cited above; see also Windus-Staginsky, *Der ägyptische König im Alten Reich*, 60–61 for *njswt-bjtj* in the Pyramid Texts.

120 One Coffin Text employing a royal title may potentially be interpreted as deriving directly from a royal funerary context. This is *CT* 831 (VII, 310, p; T1Be, T2Be, T3Be), where the offerings of the *njswt*-king are said to be pure (*jḫt njswt jw wʿb ḫt nbt jrrt n Wsjr N pn … n kɜ=f*), which could imply a ritual performed for this king—but equally could refer to a typical offering formula scenario. Both interpretations must remain conjectural.

121 See above, nn. 4, 60.

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that also in the Middle Kingdom new 'royal' texts or versions continued to be composed or included in order to render the range of potential afterlife scenarios ever more variegated and colourful.

So where does this leave us as regards the etic concepts of Royalty, Myth, and—we may add to this—Conceptual Metaphor? Clearly all three can be said to be represented in the corpus of the Coffin Texts as we understand it today. With the exception of the third, however, they were not employed by the Egyptians in a way that a non-Egyptologist might expect or be able to understand at a first glance. Yet, I hope to have demonstrated that the use of such etic concepts nevertheless helps us to analyze and describe the Egyptian evidence in terms that allow us to compare it with that of other cultures—including our own—and thus to better approximate and understand its meaning. In this context, even if it is not all that creative or new an idea, I would like to fall back on a famous (and, *NB*, highly metaphorical) aphorism by the German philosopher and writer Novalis, who asserted: 'Hypothesen sind Netze; nur der wird fangen, der auswirft',[122] translating as 'Hypotheses are nets—only he who casts (one) will catch anything'. The etic concepts discussed here, however faulty and 'porous' they may be—net-like also in this respect, perhaps?—should be viewed as equivalent to such (hypothesis-) 'nets'. They serve the purposes of 'catching' more associations, more functions, more meaning than what we would be able to identify without them. This does not mean that they cannot be superseded by newer, more appropriate concepts when the time comes;[123] neither that we should not strive to identify their emic counterparts—if this were indeed possible—or at the very least to approximate them. Clear definitions are indispensable in the use of these and any other concepts because the appropriateness for research can only be checked and verified on such an explicit and

122 Novalis was the pseudonym of Georg Philipp Friedrich Leopold Freiherr von Hardenberg (1772–1801) of the early German Romantic Movement and Jena School; for this quote see e.g. the collection of his writings Samuel, R., H.-J. Mähl, and G. Schulz (eds.), *Novalis Schriften. Zweiter Band: Das philosophische Werk* I (Darmstadt, 1965), 668. I would like to acknowledge that I first came across this aphorism in Renate Müller-Wollermann's dissertation on the state in the First Intermediate Period (*Krisenfaktoren im ägyptischen Staat des ausgehenden Alten Reiches*, PhD dissertation, Eberhard-Karls-Universität Tübingen, 1986), in which she used a model from Political Science to study the factors of crisis that would have led to the breakdown of the Old Kingdom centralized state. I have since learned that the same precept has influenced other notable scholars in search of (scientific) 'truths', having (for example) been chosen as a motto by the philosopher of science Karl Popper, and placed in front of his *Logik der Forschung: Zur Erkenntnistheorie der modernen Naturwissenschaft* (Tübingen, 1934).

123 As regards the study of the Coffin Texts, we may think of the now highly contentious term 'Democratization' which has given way to 'Demotization' in many contexts; see n. 3 above.

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firm definitional basis—one that permits other scholars to apply the same concepts and their related theories and methods to their own sources. Once again, these definitions can and must be replaced and superseded by newer, more fitting ones as new evidence comes to light. In some cases such concepts and definitions provide perhaps nothing more than a (however temporary) terminology that allows us to discuss the evidence at hand with one another. And so I close with another quote—this time one by Karl Popper:

> *Theories are passed on, not as dogmas, but rather with the challenge to discuss them and improve upon them.*[124]

124 Popper, K., *Conjectures and Refutations: The Growth of Scientific Knowledge* (London/New York, 2002 (1st ed. 1963)), 67.

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